



Theory and theory development: Guidelines for establishing theoretical gaps, foundations, contributions, and implications

Weng Marc Lim ^{a,b,c,d,1}

^a Sunway Business School, Sunway University, Sunway City, Selangor, Malaysia

^b ASU-Cintana Alliance Global Partner Affiliate Faculty, Arizona State University, Tempe, AZ, USA

^c School of Business, Law and Entrepreneurship, Swinburne University of Technology, Hawthorn, Victoria, Australia

^d Global Research Centre, Sungkyunkwan University, Suwon, Gyeonggi, Republic of Korea

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Theory
Concept theory
Relationship theory
Typology theory
Framework (or model) theory
Integrated (or hybrid) theory
Theoretical gap
Theoretical problematization
Theoretical contribution
Theoretical novelty
Theoretical interestingness
Theoretical generalizability
Theoretical adaptation
Theoretical modification
Theoretical extension
New theoretical development

ABSTRACT

Theory guides the acquisition and advancement of knowledge. Despite its importance, developing and refining theories remains a formidable task, given the inadequate clarity, inherent confusion, and compounding complexity faced by scholars in theory development. In response, this article offers clear, coherent, and constructive guidelines to tackle these challenges in theory development. Adopting the *3Es* involving the author's *expertise, experience, and exposure*, this guide offers a sequential approach to addressing *theoretical gaps, theoretical foundations, theoretical contributions, and theoretical implications*. This all-inclusive, accessible, and actionable resource seeks to benefit a diverse range of stakeholders, including both emerging and established scholars, which, in turn, contributes to ensuring the effective development of theories and, by extension, the return on value of these theories for funders, institutions, and, most importantly, the target beneficiaries (e.g., consumers, firms, society at large) of well-developed, theory-informed research.

1. Introduction

Theory traces its roots to the ancient Greek term *θεωρία* (*theōría*), meaning *contemplation*, which Plato used to frame abstract ideas and Aristotle refined into systematic frameworks.² Theory shapes understanding and guides knowledge advancement across fields, serving as the backbone of scholarly research. However, developing and refining theories remain a critical yet daunting endeavor for many scholars (see Ågerfalk, 2014; Carton, 2025; Dwivedi et al., 2022; Liang et al., 2023).

A critical review of existing guides on theory and theory development reveals a longstanding interest in clarifying how theories are conceptualized, constructed, and evaluated (Table 1). Scholars like Bagozzi (1984), Whetten (1989), and Sutton and Staw (1995) emphasize the importance of clearly articulating how and why concepts relate

while also cautioning scholars that theory development involves far more than assigning labels to phenomena. Other scholars, such as Weick (1989, 1995) and DiMaggio (1995), frame theorizing as an iterative, ongoing effort, suggesting most theoretical contributions will naturally be incremental rather than revelatory—a stance that contrasts with scholars like Campbell and Aguilera (2022), who explicitly advocate for more revelatory contributions yet similarly urge scholars to push beyond surface-level insights. Critically, these foundational discussions continue to influence scholarly debates on what constitutes meaningful theoretical contributions and how such contributions should best be communicated. Yet, as research continues to evolve, newer perspectives have emerged. Corley and Gioia (2011), for instance, along with Shepherd and Suddaby (2017), confront shifting epistemological and methodological stances, implying that scholars must remain open and adaptable

E-mail addresses: lim@wengmarc.com, marcl@sunway.edu.my, wengmarc@asu.edu, marclim@swin.edu.au.

¹ ORCID: 0000-0001-7196-1923.

² As per Plato's *Republic* on contemplation of forms as the highest kind of knowing and Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* on *epistēmē* (theoretical knowledge), *phronēsis* (practical wisdom), and *technē* (productive skill).

<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2025.115745>

Received 28 December 2024; Received in revised form 8 August 2025; Accepted 23 September 2025

Available online 27 October 2025

0148-2963/© 2025 The Author(s). Published by Elsevier Inc. This is an open access article under the CC BY license (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>).

Table 1
Key takeaways on theory development.

Author(s)	Article	Journal	Focus	Key takeaway(s)
Davis (1971)	That's interesting! Towards a phenomenology of sociology and a sociology of phenomenology	<i>Philosophy of the Social Sciences</i>	Addresses how certain theories are distinguished as “interesting,” proposing that interesting theories challenge the established assumptions held by their audiences.	Suggests that theories become interesting when they contradict widely-held assumptions or “taken-for-granted truths,” thereby provoking audiences to reconsider their foundational beliefs.
Astley and Van de Ven (1983)	Central perspectives and debates in organization theory	<i>Administrative Science Quarterly</i>	Addresses whether and how scholars should unify diverse theoretical perspectives or maintain pluralism.	Suggests that multiple theories are valuable for capturing complexity, cautioning against any single, overarching view that may limit understanding of varied processes.
Bagozzi (1984)	A prospectus for theory construction in marketing	<i>Journal of Marketing</i>	Addresses foundational questions about how theories should be constructed, presenting two contrasting paradigms in the form of logical empiricism (received view) and the realist perspective (holistic construal) and proposing formal criteria for theory development.	Suggests that theory development should integrate conceptual meaning (via precise definitions and clearly specified relationships among concepts), empirical meaning (through explicit correspondence rules linking theoretical concepts to empirical observations), and consideration of spurious meaning (recognizing random and systematic errors) to enhance theoretical rigor and empirical testability.
Bacharach (1989)	Organizational theories: Some criteria for evaluation	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses the distinction between conceptual and empirical domains, questioning when a theory is adequately specified.	Suggests defining constructs (concepts), relationships, and assumptions clearly while emphasizing falsifiability and well-delineated boundaries to strengthen theoretical rigor.
Van de Ven (1989)	Nothing is quite so practical as a good theory	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses how theory can bridge the gap between academic work and practical application, challenging the view that theory lacks real-world relevance.	Suggests that a good theory not only advances scholarly discussion but also guides real-world decision-making, highlighting its dual value for academia and practice.
Weick (1989)	Theory construction as disciplined imagination	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses the role of imagination in building theories while balancing creativity with disciplined research.	Suggests that theoretical innovation emerges from playful exploration combined with rigorous theoretical grounding and thus encouraging openness to unexpected insights within a systematic framework.
Whetten (1989)	What constitutes a theoretical contribution?	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses the essential components of a theoretical contribution by focusing on the what, where, when, who, why, and how.	Suggests how identifying concepts, clarifying their relationships, and explaining underlying logic and contextual boundaries can help determine whether a theory truly advances the field.
DiMaggio (1995)	Comments on “What theory is not”	<i>Administrative Science Quarterly</i>	Addresses the difference between (merely) naming concepts and forming real explanations.	Suggests that theory must go beyond classification and should offer causal explanations, warning against conflating loose conceptual labels with substantive theorizing.
Sutton and Staw (1995)	What theory is not	<i>Administrative Science Quarterly</i>	Addresses data, references, or lists of concepts, arguing that these alone do not constitute theory and thus challenging scholars to provide deeper causal explanations.	Suggests that naming concepts or presenting empirical patterns is insufficient and urging explicit articulation of how and why relationships occur.
Van de Ven and Poole (1995)	Explaining development and change in organizations	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses the mechanisms (life cycle, teleology, dialectics, evolution) through which something evolves, prompting reflection on the nature of process theories.	Suggests specifying which “motor of change” informs the theoretical approach and reminding that multiple pathways may explain how and why something develops over time.
Weick (1995)	What theory is not, theorizing is	<i>Administrative Science Quarterly</i>	Addresses the continuous process of theorizing, arguing that theory is not static but dynamically shaped by ongoing sensemaking.	Suggests that theory development should be seen as iterative refinement and thus urges to embrace theory as an evolving conversation rather than a final, rigid product.
MacKenzie (2003)	The dangers of poor construct conceptualization	<i>Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science</i>	Addresses the critical importance of clearly defining constructs (concepts), arguing that inadequate conceptualization undermines construct validity, measurement accuracy, and, in turn, theoretical rigor and empirical conclusions.	Suggests that poor conceptualization leads to contaminated or deficient measures, measurement model misspecification, weak theoretical rationales, and reduced validity of empirical conclusions.
Suddaby (2010)	Construct clarity in theories of management and organization	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses methodological issues surrounding construct (concept) clarity, emphasizing the essential criteria for clearly defining constructs (concepts), their scope conditions, relationships with other constructs (concepts), and overall coherence.	Suggests that clearly defined constructs (concepts) are fundamental to theory building and effective communication among scholars, highlighting that unclear construct (concept) definitions impede theory development and empirical validation, and suggests that construct (concept) clarity involves precise definitions, explicit scope conditions, clear relationships with related constructs (concept), and logical coherence.
Corley and Gioia (2011)	Building theory about theory building: What constitutes a theoretical contribution?	<i>Academy of Management Review</i>	Addresses how to define a theoretical contribution by weighing academic versus practical relevance while balancing rigor with creativity.	Suggests that contributions require a clear rationale for why a theory matters both academically and practically, advocating innovation that resonates with scholarly debates and real-world concerns.

(continued on next page)

Table 1 (continued)

Author(s)	Article	Journal	Focus	Key takeaway(s)
MacInnis (2011)*	A framework for conceptual contributions in marketing	<i>Journal of Marketing</i>	Addresses the types of conceptual contributions by providing clarity on how conceptualization advances knowledge through debating, explicating, envisioning, and relating, and offering a structured typology of conceptual advances.	Suggests that conceptual advances require clear identification and differentiation of conceptual goals (e.g., advocating, delineating, differentiating, identifying, integrating, refuting, revising, summarizing) to enhance scholarly understanding, theory development, and practical impact.
Cornelissen and Durand (2014)	Moving forward: Developing theoretical contributions in management studies	<i>Journal of Management Studies</i>	Addresses the reasoning processes underlying theoretical contributions and provides a typology comprising analogical and counterfactual reasoning (heuristic, causal, and constitutive) that scholars use to develop novel and significant theoretical contributions.	Suggests that novel theoretical contributions emerge through analogical or counterfactual reasoning processes, such as heuristic reasoning (developing new assumptions and concepts), causal reasoning (modelling novel causal hypotheses), and constitutive reasoning (formulating comprehensive new conceptual frameworks).
Shepherd and Suddaby (2017)	Theory building: A review and integration	<i>Journal of Management</i>	Addresses the interplay among competing epistemological and methodological stances on theory building by questioning how best to reconcile diverse approaches into a coherent framework.	Suggests a synthesis of these viewpoints in an integrated framework that emphasizes systematic, transparent methods for building strong, coherent theory and encourages to consider the interplay of actors, contexts, and processes when developing new theoretical insights.
Tellis (2017)	Interesting and impactful research: On phenomena, theory, and writing	<i>Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science</i>	Addresses what makes theory interesting and impactful and where to begin in theory building.	Suggests that theory is interesting and impactful when it refutes audience assumptions, with attention rising as refutation increases but persuasion peaking before falling, so claims should challenge prior beliefs without tipping into absurdity, and that theory building should start from phenomena.
Varadarajan (2017)	Musings on interesting and impactful theory and research	<i>Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science</i>	Addresses the relationship between interestingness, impact, and simplicity in theory development, highlighting that impactful theories offer clear and parsimonious explanations with broad explanatory power and practical relevance.	Suggests that effective theories are characterized by simplicity, parsimony, generality, consilience (alignment with knowledge in other fields), and predictiveness while cautioning against equating simplicity with truth and emphasizing that impactful theories must also be rigorously validated empirically and capable of driving meaningful insights and practical implications.
Hulland (2020) ***	Conceptual review papers: Revisiting existing research to develop and refine theory	<i>Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science</i>	Addresses the methodological issues surrounding conceptual review papers, clarifying their distinction from other theory development methods, outlining best practices, and highlighting the importance of systematically reviewing, synthesizing, and critically evaluating existing knowledge.	Suggests that strong conceptual review papers require systematic approaches to domain definition, thorough integration and synthesis of literature, resolution of inconsistencies, highlighting of research gaps, and clear agendas for future research, and in doing so, emphasizes that effective conceptual reviews offer novel, engaging, and actionable theoretical insights to advance the field.
Jaakkola (2020)*	Designing conceptual articles: Four approaches	<i>AMS Review</i>	Addresses methodological issues related to designing conceptual papers by offering clear guidance on how scholars can structure and justify their conceptual research designs through four distinct approaches (theory adaptation, theory synthesis, model, and typology).	Suggests that conceptual articles must clearly justify their choices of concepts (theories), explicate their roles in analysis, and transparently articulate the logic underpinning their arguments while introducing four structured templates (theory adaptation, theory synthesis, model, and typology) that scholars can use to guide conceptual (theoretical) development.
Tihanyi (2020)	From “that’s interesting” to “that’s important”	<i>Academy of Management Journal</i>	Addresses the potential trade-offs between pursuing research considered “interesting” versus “important,” arguing for the prioritization of research with meaningful stakeholder relevance over counterintuitive or surprising findings.	Suggests that research should shift focus from solely pursuing counterintuitive insights (interestingness) toward addressing significant organizational and societal challenges (importance) and thus urges scholars to conduct research that provides solutions to real-world problems and positively influences practice and society.
Zeithaml et al. (2020)	A theories-in-use approach to building marketing theory	<i>Journal of Marketing</i>	Addresses methodological issues related to developing theory using a theories-in-use (TIU) approach, highlighting how TIU contrasts with other inductive and deductive approaches, and proposes guidelines for systematically applying TIU to construct relevant, impactful, and novel theories.	Suggests that systematically uncovering stakeholders’ mental models (TIU) provides a fertile foundation for organic theory construction and thus emphasizing the importance of explicitly engaging practitioners, systematically eliciting and abstracting stakeholder insights, and constructing novel, practically relevant theoretical propositions that extend beyond borrowing theories from other disciplines.

(continued on next page)

Table 1 (continued)

Author(s)	Article	Journal	Focus	Key takeaway(s)
Mukherjee et al. (2022) ***	Guidelines for advancing theory and practice through bibliometric research	<i>Journal of Business Research</i>	Addresses the gap in linking bibliometric analysis to both theory development and practical impact, highlighting criticisms that many reviews using this analytical technique remain overly descriptive and disconnected from substantive theoretical and practical contributions.	Suggests a multifaceted framework that (i) identifies 10 distinct theoretical and practical contributions of bibliometric reviews (e.g., discovery of knowledge clusters, objective impact assessment) and (ii) proposes seven evaluative factors comprising completeness, exposition, importance, novelty, rigor, timeliness, and value to guide scholars and referees in developing, demonstrating, and judging theoretical and practical contributions of bibliometric studies.
Tsang (2022)	That's interesting! A flawed article has influenced generations of management researchers	<i>Journal of Management Inquiry</i>	Addresses Davis's (1971) influential proposition that good theories must be interesting, highlighting flaws and negative consequences of prioritizing interestingness over scientific rigor.	Suggests against the widespread emphasis on interestingness (counterintuitivity) as a primary criterion for theory evaluation, cautioning that it encourages post-hoc hypothesis formulation, undermines replication studies, and distracts from the proper goals of scientific research, thereby emphasizing the need to prioritize empirical rigor, truth, and meaningful societal impact over (mere) interestingness.
Van Hierden et al. (2022)	BUILD: A five-step process to develop theory-driven social marketing interventions	<i>Journal of Social Marketing</i>	Addresses the need to systematically guide scholars and practitioners in developing and implementing theory-driven interventions by proposing a structured, practical five-step BUILD process (begin with objective, use theory, initiate program design, let's produce, and develop engagement plan).	Suggests that systematically mapping theory to intervention components through the BUILD process improves clarity and rigor in interventions by explicitly demonstrating how theory informs the selection and design of intervention activities, thereby enhancing theoretical contribution, intervention effectiveness, and practical relevance.
Golder et al. (2023)**	Learning from data: An empirics-first approach to relevant knowledge generation	<i>Journal of Marketing</i>	Addresses the value of an empirics-first approach by emphasizing the importance of starting from real-world phenomena prior to theory development to enhance the novelty and relevance of insights.	Suggests that beginning research from empirical observations rather than theory can uncover novel insights and reveal research questions otherwise overlooked while emphasizing that empirics-first research is complementary to theory development as it provides real-world grounding that can subsequently inform and advance theory.
Hollebeek et al. (2024)*	Crafting conceptual proposition-based contributions: The 7C framework	<i>Psychology & Marketing</i>	Addresses methodological issues related to the design of conceptual proposition-based research by proposing a structured framework (the 7C framework) that synthesizes the topic and theory selection process, proposition development, and evaluative guidelines for conceptual (theoretical) rigor.	Suggests a synthesis of Ulaga et al.'s (2021) intra-propositional guidelines (clarity, consistency, conciseness, contribution) with newly introduced inter-propositional guidelines (conceptual distinctiveness, comprehensiveness, coherence) to develop and evaluate theoretically rigorous, meaningful sets of propositions.
Homer and Lim (2024)	Theory development in a globalized world: Bridging "doing as the Romans do" with "understanding why the Romans do it"	<i>Global Business and Organizational Excellence</i>	Addresses the tensions between micro-, meso-, and macro-level theorizing by arguing for the symbiotic integration of these theoretical perspectives to better capture global complexities.	Suggests reconciling micro, meso, and macro theoretical perspectives by highlighting the importance of cultural contextualization, interdisciplinary collaboration, mixed methods, and progressive layers, among others, to develop contextually relevant theories in a globalized context.
Bartunek and Lei (2025)	Creating theory that is generative for scholarship and practice	<i>Organizational Psychology Review</i>	Addresses what makes theory generative for scholarship and practice and how to foster it, distinguishing generative capacity (evidenced by others' uptake) from standard explanation, and identifying processes that hinder or facilitate its development.	Suggests that theory is generative when it challenges guiding assumptions, raises fundamental questions, and motivates others' thinking and action over time by cultivating doubt and imagination, engaging diverse stakeholders, working with multiple and even contradictory assumptions and perspectives, and iterating with disciplined reflexivity while warning that closed communities, sloganization of ideas, and unexamined commonsense assumptions stifle generativity.
Bhardwaj et al. (2025)	Theorizing as problem solving: A pragmatist perspective on the logic of pursuit	<i>Strategy Science</i>	Addresses the process through which novel research programs are developed by introducing the "logic of pursuit" as a pathway between theory discovery and justification while emphasizing pragmatic evaluation in scholarly endeavors.	Suggests that theorizing should be regarded as a structured, pragmatic problem-solving process guided by non-empirical criteria and thus urges that scholars select theories to pursue based on their anticipated effectiveness, practical applicability, and potential to significantly advance scholarly discourse.
Carton (2025)	The six dimensions of strong theory	<i>Organization Science</i>	Addresses the dimensions of strong theory by synthesizing insights on strong theory from commentaries into six core dimensions (accuracy, actionability, generality, importance,	Suggests that no single theory can simultaneously optimize all six dimensions of strong theory and thus recommends that scholars strategically prioritize fewer dimensions per article while collectively

(continued on next page)

Table 1 (continued)

Author(s)	Article	Journal	Focus	Key takeaway(s)
Hollebeek et al. (2025)	Guidelines for theory selection: The IMPACT framework	<i>Psychology & Marketing</i>	interestingness, and simplicity) and critically analyzing trade-offs among these dimensions. Addresses the selection of appropriate macro-foundational theories to achieve impactful research by proposing six structured guidelines comprising interestingness, matching, parsimony, applicability, conceptual rigor, and testability (collectively abbreviated as “IMPACT”) to guide the theory-selection process.	balancing all dimensions across multiple studies within a program of research. Suggests that selecting appropriate macro-foundational theories significantly shapes (scientific) research impact and proposes the IMPACT guidelines (interestingness, matching, parsimony, applicability, conceptual rigor, and testability) that scholars can strategically apply to guide their theory selection and theoretical integration processes to enhance the likelihood of producing rigorous, meaningful, and impactful theoretical contributions.
Sun et al. (2025)	Rebalancing novelty with rigor and relevance in information systems research	<i>MIS Quarterly</i>	Addresses what is novelty and how to balance it with rigor and relevance via a novelty–rigor–relevance triad.	Suggests treating novelty as originality in constructs, relationships, or methods while balancing it with rigor (e.g., clarity in conceptualization and operationalization, transparency of actions or decisions taken and the associated logics or rationales, triangulation of methods and results) and relevance (e.g., what is new, why it matters, how it endures).
Venkatesh (2025)	Leveraging context: Re-thinking research processes to make “contributions to theory”	<i>Information Systems Research</i>	Addresses how to leverage contextualization systematically across four research steps (defining the problem, anchoring to prior research, seeking novelty, and reporting practices) to strengthen both contributions of theory (applying theory to understand phenomena) and contributions to theory (advancing or developing theory).	Suggests that contextualized research should be judged by its ability to produce contributions to theory, that is, to advance core theoretical knowledge, especially in reference disciplines, by moving beyond application to phenomena, enabled by richly articulating and connecting contextual characteristics to archetypal problems, engaging deeply with and extending prior theory, integrating or recombining knowledge in novel ways, specifying and challenging assumptions, developing new theories or taxonomies, and transparently reporting contextual details to clarify boundary conditions and facilitate cumulative knowledge building.
The present author	Theory and theory development: Guidelines for establishing theoretical gaps, foundations, contributions, and implications	<i>Journal of Business Research</i>	Addresses the need for an all-inclusive, accessible, and actionable resource that addresses inadequate clarity (e.g., among different types of theoretical contributions), inherent confusion (e.g., between concept versus construct and contribution versus implication), and compounding complexity (e.g., varied expectation and understanding among stakeholders) in theory development, and counters them with clarity (i.e., drawing explicit distinctions), coherence (i.e., establishing logical interrelations), and constructiveness (i.e., proposing pragmatic steps) through a sequential approach for spotting and problematizing theoretical gaps, establishing theoretical foundations, achieving various types of theoretical contributions, and articulating theoretical implications.	Suggests that good theory development requires (i) well-problematised theoretical gaps (practical and theoretical), (ii) strong theoretical foundations (what the theory is, why the theory matters, how the theory has been used, how the present study applies the theory, and how the study contributes back to the theory), (iii) structured types of theoretical contributions (generalizability, adaptation, modification, extension, or new development) with clear novelty (incremental versus revelatory) and interestingness (counterintuitivity, paradoxicality, or noteworthiness), and (iv) actionable implications (retrospection and reimagination) that guide ongoing research and practice. The guide is grounded in the author’s 3Es (expertise, experience, exposure) and underscores the importance of clarity and utility in enabling diverse stakeholders, especially scholars, to navigate and strengthen theory development.

Notes: The key takeaways for each article reflect the author’s interpretation of these works and may differ from the perspectives of other readers. * = Guides that use the term “conceptual” rather than “theoretical” but are nonetheless included because concepts are viewed as a subset of theory, as will be illustrated in later sections of this guide. ** = Empirics-first approach to theory development. *** = Retrospective-prospective approach to theory development.

to diverse perspectives to effectively advance theory and maintain its relevance amid evolving norms and expectations. Extending this line, Bartunek and Lei (2025) argue that theorizing should also be judged by its generative capacity, that is, the extent to which it challenges guiding assumptions, raises fundamental questions, and is taken up by others, enabled by cultivating doubt and imagination, engaging diverse communities, working with even contradictory assumptions, and iterating with disciplined reflexivity. Others caution against poor practices (e.g., inadequate conceptualization; MacKenzie, 2003; Suddaby, 2010),

clarify the processes of reasoning (e.g., heuristic, causal, constitutive, theories-in-use; Cornelissen & Durand, 2014; Zeithaml et al., 2020), elucidate the complexities associated with theory selection, interestingness, impact, and simplicity (e.g., Hollebeek et al., 2025; Varadarajan, 2017), and emphasize the novelty–rigor–relevance triad as a necessary balance that sharpens clarity on what is new, why it matters, and how it endures (Sun et al., 2025), thus further underscoring the multifaceted nature of (effective) theory development. Complementing these developments, Golder et al. (2023) advocate an empirics-first

approach, emphasizing that starting with real-world phenomena before formal theory development can provide valuable empirical insights. Although initially appearing to challenge traditional approaches, their proposal underscores the continued necessity of theory, noting that empirical findings alone do not guarantee theoretical contribution. Hence, their empirics-first approach serves as a complementary path, reinforcing theory's pivotal role in translating empirical observations into generalizable and actionable knowledge. Others advocate retrospection through conceptual (Hulland, 2020) or bibliometric (Mukherjee et al., 2022) reviews (among many other review types; Lim et al., 2022), emphasize problem-solving through theory-driven interventions (Van Hierden et al., 2022), and employ systematic contextualization as a pathway to strengthen both contributions of and contributions to theory (Venkatesh, 2025), suggesting that platforms for theory development, as well as the impacts of developed theories, are multifaceted. Further extending this conversation, Bhardwaj et al. (2025) reframe theorizing as an iterative problem-solving process grounded in pragmatism, emphasizing the importance of strategically pursuing promising theoretical paths while abandoning less fruitful ones, with Sun et al. (2025) reminding that the value of such pursuits rests not only in novelty but also in endurance, that is, the capacity of contributions to remain meaningful and reusable over time. Carton (2025) similarly underscores the necessity for scholars to explicitly acknowledge and manage inherent trade-offs in theory development, cautioning against unrealistic attempts to simultaneously achieve perfection across all criteria. Their works reflect contemporary challenges in reconciling diverse approaches to theory development into coherent frameworks capable of preserving the integrity of individual perspectives yet promoting complementarity rather than competition. These guides also demonstrate that publishing insights on how to build and improve theory remains a fixture in leading journals, reflecting an enduring appetite for resources that can help scholars navigate theoretical complexities.

Although existing guides on theory and theory development are insightful, they may, unfortunately, though unintentionally, suffer from *fragmentation*, making them difficult to apply in practice (*1st gap*). To illustrate, Whetten (1989) provided foundational insights into defining a theory by identifying core components (i.e., what, where, when, who, why, and how) but less so on the extent of theoretical contributions. Likewise, Sutton and Staw (1995) and Weick (1995) have strongly emphasized what theory is not and how theorizing unfolds, respectively, yet their focus remains largely abstract and conceptual without clear sequential guidance for implementation. Similarly, Corley and Gioia (2011) offered guidance for evaluating theoretical contributions, yet stopped short of fully connecting such evaluations back to theoretical gaps and forward to theoretical implications. More recently, Carton (2025) expanded the scope of Shepherd and Suddaby's (2017) review of 58 theory-building articles in management by comprehensively analyzing 284 commentaries on strong theory, from which he distilled six key criteria (accuracy, actionability, generality, importance, interestingness, and simplicity), explicitly acknowledging that fully addressing every criterion simultaneously is inherently unrealistic and thus advising scholars to strategically prioritize some over others. However, Carton's (2025) guidance did not clearly explain how scholars can effectively prioritize these criteria in practice and also seems disconnected from the challenging reality of scholarly publishing, wherein reviewers from diverse theoretical traditions often simultaneously demand multiple, or even all, criteria to be satisfied. Hence, despite its comprehensiveness, Carton's (2025) guide, which is one of the most recent at the time of writing, still leaves unresolved the issue of providing integrated guidance that is practically useful, not only for pursuing lines of inquiry (Bhardwaj et al., 2025), but also for implementation in the process of theory development itself, potentially leaving scholars back at square one. Collectively, these seminal guides thus underscore an implicit fragmentation in how theory development is approached, as each focuses individually on particular aspects rather

than offering a coherent, integrated approach that systematically clarifies theoretical gaps, establishes theoretical foundations, formulates theoretical contributions, and articulates theoretical implications in a manner that, to the best extent possible, is widely applicable—an issue this article explicitly endeavors to address.

Beyond fragmentation, theory development guidance faces another crucial issue—namely, insufficient clarity regarding what constitutes *interestingness*, and thus, lacks clear criteria for recognizing theoretical contributions that can genuinely attract and advance scholarly discourse in meaningful ways (*2nd gap*). Notably, Campbell and Aguilera (2022, p. 523) emphasized that an article can be well-written yet still fail if “there is nothing new enough to make the reader go: ‘Aha! That’s interesting!’,” implying that the presented ideas remain too incremental. Despite acknowledging its importance, the notion of interestingness itself continues to be, arguably, ill-defined, as it tends to be understood simply as “counterintuitive” (Davis, 1971)—a framing that may encourage scholars to appeal to audiences rather than pursue importance and truth (Pillutla & Thau, 2013; Tihanyi, 2020; Tsang, 2022)—or as “insightful”—a descriptor characterized by the revelation of contrasts or opposites becoming apparent (e.g., relating the unrelated, seeing the unseen, simplifying the complex; MacInnis, 2011, p. 139), yet one that often lacks the theoretical tension needed to genuinely “move the needle” (Campbell & Aguilera, 2022, p. 523). Consistent with this concern, Tellis (2017) frames interestingness as refutation of prevailing assumptions and shows, via an audience-response curve, that attention rises as refutation increases while persuasion peaks before declining, meaning that claims should challenge beliefs without overreaching into absurdity, so as to clarify but not exhaust what counts as interesting. Yet, what appears to be noticeably lacking is a more inclusive understanding that accommodates multiple forms through which a theory may be deemed interesting, thereby restoring the balance needed to advance theoretical insight with a logic of pursuit (Bhardwaj et al., 2025) that complements rather than compromises importance (Pillutla & Thau, 2013; Tihanyi, 2020) and truth (Tsang, 2022). The recent large-scale review of strong theory by Carton (2025) supports this observation by highlighting that interestingness is typically associated with “assumptions-challenging insights” presented in “engrossing narratives,” yet his encapsulation remains descriptive without clearly delineating how scholars can engage in different approaches to making theories interesting. In turn, these observations underscore the need for a clearer, structured typology of theoretical interestingness—one that identifies the distinct pathways through which a theory can generate tension, meaningfully and truthfully, to attract and advance scholarly discourse. This typology of interestingness is thus another critical aspect that the present article explicitly endeavors to address.

Closely related to the issue of interestingness is the threshold for *novelty*, specifically how much incremental advancement is required before an idea can be considered revelatory or sufficiently novel, which remains subjective, if not, controversial (*3rd gap*). This subjectivity is evident in fundamental disagreements over what constitutes theory and theorizing (e.g., Sutton & Staw, 1995; Weick, 1995; Whetten, 1989), as well as ongoing debates on whether expecting revelatory contributions from every research is even realistic (e.g., Campbell & Aguilera, 2022; Carton, 2025; Corley & Gioia, 2011). These debates highlight the necessity of gaining not just a clear, oftentimes implicit understanding of theoretical gaps, theoretical foundations, theoretical contributions, and theoretical implications, but also providing explicit guidance on these aspects of theory and theory development in a realistic manner. Such pragmatism, as illustrated throughout this article, acknowledges variations in theory development (e.g., levels of theoretical novelty), promotes inclusivity (e.g., types of theoretical contributions), and by extension, democratizes theory building (e.g., iterations in theory development), contrasting sharply with idealistic positions that overlook contemporary academic realities, particularly the need for theory to deliver timely scientific and practical utility (Corley & Gioia, 2011; Van de Ven, 1989; Tihanyi, 2020), and that implicitly reserve theory

development to an elite minority capable of revelatory breakthroughs (e.g., reflected in the implicit yet pervasive norm of publishing a small, influential subset of authors and citing theories in premier journals),³ which may require years to achieve and disseminate.⁴

The urgency for the present guide, which seeks to address the three identified gaps in extant guides on theory development (i.e., fragmentation, interestingness, and novelty), also emerges from significant changes in the landscape of research. Noteworthy, an increasing number of individuals are pursuing and completing PhDs (Hoang et al., 2023; Nietzel, 2024; Sarrico, 2022), and institutions are shifting from education-focused to research-intensive orientations—a transformation driven by evolving academic priorities (i.e., a growing emphasis on research and research-informed teaching over traditional teaching or “teaching as is”; Bull et al., 2025), competitive pressures from rankings (i.e., the drive to improve institutional standings in national and international assessments; Grolleau & Meunier, 2024), and stakeholder demands for actionable solutions (i.e., the expectation for higher education institutions to deliver practical and impactful research outcomes; Compagnucci & Spigarelli, 2020). These factors have led to a surge in research (Wilcox, 2023), which, in turn, highlights the need for a structured guide to understand and develop theory effectively—without which findings risk fragmenting into isolated insights that fail to advance coherent understanding of key phenomena.

Moreover, access to certain publishers remains limited (e.g., Academy of Management), particularly those available only through individual memberships or those with fewer titles, which are less attractive to libraries. Ironically, while libraries are supposedly the treasure troves of knowledge, they often face significant budget constraints (Adekoya, 2023), limiting their ability to acquire these resources. Many essential guides, considered “must-reads” by the scholarly community who subscribe to premier journals (e.g., Bacharach, 1989; Sutton & Staw, 1995; Weick, 1989, 1995; Whetten, 1989), were published before institutional open access agreements became common (e.g., Council of Australian University Librarians (CAUL) in Australia, Canadian Research Knowledge Network (CRKN) in Canada, Higher Education Electronic Resources Consortium (Konsortium Sumber Elektronik Pendidikan Tinggi, KONSEPT) in Malaysia, and Joint Information Systems Committee (JISC) in the UK). This issue particularly affects scholars from developing countries, who contribute significantly to the growth in research (To & Yu, 2023), but often face restricted access to up-to-date resources (Harley, 2016). Although recent initiatives such as India’s One Nation One Subscription (ONOS, 2025) endeavor to democratize access to scholarly journals across public institutions (Koley, 2024; Madalli, 2025), such progressive models do not necessarily extend to private institutions and have yet to be adopted in most developing countries, thereby remaining an exception rather than the norm. The present guide provides a compilation of the focus and key takeaways from earlier guides on theory and theory development (Table 1) and is made open access to address these barriers, thereby offering readers a consolidated resource for navigating theory and theory development.

Despite the risk of appearing “textbook-like,” guidance articles endure because new perspectives, including the repositioning of existing insights to yield fresh outlooks, continually arise in discussions of theory

and its development, thereby necessitating updates. Yet, some may question whether another guide on theory and theory development truly contributes novel insights or simply rehashes established knowledge. The appropriateness of a guide such as the present one arises from the fact that what appears elementary can, in reality, serve an essential function. Previous guides on theory and theory development have appeared in premier journals that demand originality for publication, such as *Academy of Management Review*, *Administrative Science Quarterly*, and *Journal of Marketing*. Their continued publication of such works over the years, even within the same outlet or across sister journals (*Academy of Management Journal*), indicates that these guides do, in fact, offer novelty, especially when they address debates, alleviate misconceptions, and respond to new contexts. Such contributions highlight an openness to “how-to” resources that adapt to the evolving research landscape, showing that multiple guides can coexist when they respond to distinct critiques and knowledge gaps. Knowledge progresses over time, and journals, as the fountain and sentinel of knowledge, require both fresh perspectives and interventions to address emerging debates and misunderstandings. Such reasoning suggests that a well-grounded, systematically crafted guide, like the present one, can provide a novel, structured framework for theory development, even if the topic has been explored before. The present guide aligns with this tradition by proposing clear, coherent, and constructive guidance for theory development.

This guide answers the call to encourage and support theory development (e.g., Barney, 2018; Cornelissen, 2017; Gümüşay & Reinecke, 2024; Makadok et al., 2018; Thatcher & Fisher, 2022; Yadav, 2010) across all types of scholarly research (i.e., review, conceptual, and empirical—e.g., qualitative, quantitative; see Lim et al., 2022) and joins the scholarly conversation by reconciling persistent issues on theory and theory development. Grounded in the author’s *expertise* (based on own work, either past or present), *experience* (based on own development shaped by expertise and exposure), and *exposure* (based on known resources)—known as the 3Es (Kraus et al., 2022)—this guide, which is *conceptual* in nature, follows a sequential approach typical of research to address theoretical gaps (introduction: past motivating present), theoretical foundations (literature review: connecting past to present), theoretical contributions (discussion: present), and theoretical implications (conclusion: connecting present to future), wherein this all-inclusive, accessible, and actionable resource seeks to benefit a diverse range of stakeholders involved in scholarly research (e.g., crafting better theories among scholars at all stages, evaluating and demanding better theories among stakeholders, including funders, peers (editors, reviewers), institutions, and society at large). More specifically, this guide is *all-inclusive* by serving as a one-stop resource on theory and theory development. A start-to-finish roadmap—spanning theoretical gaps, theoretical foundations, theoretical contributions, and theoretical implications—reduces the need for readers to consult multiple sources, thereby *positioning* this piece as an integrated reference for both emerging and established scholars.⁵ The guide is also *accessible* because it employs language and visuals that simplify complex ideas without compromising rigor. Concrete examples and straightforward illustrations help readers visualize theory-building steps, ensuring the material remains approachable for newcomers while offering depth for more seasoned scholars. The guide likewise endeavors to be *actionable* by providing explicit recommendations that can be immediately applied—ranging from spotting and problematizing pertinent theoretical gaps to establishing strong theoretical foundations, achieving

³ For example, Mindel and Ciriello’s (2025) audit of elite business journals reveals systemic editorial conflicts of interest, demonstrating how editorial practices implicitly favor a small elite of scholars who disproportionately influence scholarly discourse, thus effectively reserving opportunities for significant theoretical contributions to insiders rather than the wider community.

⁴ For instance, Lysyakov et al.’s (2025) study on firm-generated content on social media was originally submitted to the *Journal of Marketing* on April 28, 2022, but was only accepted and published online on February 11, 2025. Notably, the context of their study was “Twitter,” which was rebranded as “X” on July 23, 2023—over a year after the manuscript’s original submission and nearly two years before its publication.

⁵ The statements herein exemplify “positioning” by joining the extant conversation and telling a compelling storyline that frames and signals the contribution against the existing state of affairs to the intended audience (see Koskela-Huotari, 2024). When extrapolated to theory, *theoretical positioning* can thus refer to the delineation of a theory’s scope of assumptions and contributions against competing and/or complementary theories.

interesting and novel theoretical contributions, and articulating clear theoretical implications. Sequential strategies clarify “why” and “how” each step is undertaken while pragmatic guidance addresses typical stumbling blocks (e.g., in conceptualization, operationalization, publication). These features collectively enable scholars to translate theoretical insights into tangible outcomes and thus strengthen both the quality and impact of their research. Importantly, effective and well-motivated research is crucial to avoid wasting resources such as effort, time, money, and networks, regardless of whether these resources come from public, institutional, or personal sources. This guide argues that a deep understanding of theory and its facets (i.e., gaps, foundations, contributions, and implications) is necessary. Scholars are directed to pursue answers to questions that are not only unknown but also require rigorous reasoning (theory development) and testing (theory validation) to establish theory confidently. Kurt Lewin’s sayings, “Nothing is as practical as a good theory” and “The best way to understand something is to try to change it,” aptly capture and lend support to this approach (Greenwood & Levin, 1998; Yorks, 2005).

2. What is theory?

2.1. Principles of a (good) theory

A theory acts as a *lens to comprehend, explain, and predict phenomenon* (Fig. 1 Panel A). At its core, a theory involves *abstraction* (identifying *what, where, when, who*) and *assumption* (explaining *why, how*) (Bacharach, 1989; Dubin, 1978; Jaccard & Jacoby, 2020; Whetten, 1989).⁶ *Abstraction* helps define the context and scope of the phenomenon by delineating its key boundaries and elements, addressing questions like *what* is happening, *where* it can happen, *when* it occurs, and *who* is involved.⁷ *Assumptions* provide the underlying rationale for the mechanisms and relationships driving the phenomenon, addressing questions like *why* it is happening and *how* it occurs. For instance, Moriuchi et al. (2025) developed a model to explain consumers’ smartphone addiction by initially establishing that smartphone addiction (*what*) happens *when* mobile apps (*where*) constantly send push notifications to smartphone users (*who*) before going on to show that smartphone addiction is the reason *why* push notifications from mobile apps reduce overall wellbeing and *how* engagement by contributing rather than engagement by consuming can mitigate the negative impact of smartphone addiction on overall wellbeing.

A good theory is distinguished by its dual capacity to be both *conceptualizable* and *operationalizable* (Fig. 1 Panel B).

Conceptualization is about *explainability* and involves clearly defining and structuring the fundamental components of a theory—that is, explicitly identifying its core concepts and the relationships among them. *Concepts* should be *definable*, which implies that they should be defined clearly and concisely so that readers can easily understand the elements that constitute the phenomenon. For instance, Moriuchi et al. (2025) defined push notifications as alerts (*what*) that mobile apps (*where*) used to notify users (*who*) of new content or messages (*when*). *Relationships* between these concepts must be *linkable* and can be done by forming propositions in qualitative research (broad, e.g., usability) or hypotheses in quantitative research (specific, e.g., ease of use, usefulness). This process, in turn, ensures that the theory is comprehensible

and provides a coherent lens that can guide inquiry and the development of understanding. For instance, Moriuchi et al. (2025) hypothesized that push notifications significantly predict the development of smartphone addiction because such notifications can cause smartphone users to compulsively attend to and engage with them, especially when they are feature-rich and demand immediate attention (*why*), making it difficult for users to disengage and thereby transforming episodic interruptions into patterns of problematic, addictive smartphone use (*how*).

Operationalization (testability) translates these abstract components into measurable constructs and manipulable variables. *Constructs* are *measurable* and thus *observable* elements that represent abstract concepts, even if they are (initially) latent. For instance, constructs such as push notifications and smartphone addiction were quantified by Moriuchi et al. (2025) through surveys and scales, linking abstract concepts to observable data. These constructs become *variables* when they are *manipulated* or *tested* in relation to other variables. For example, constructs can be operationalized as independent variables (or predictors—e.g., push notifications), dependent variables (or outcomes—e.g., overall wellbeing), mediating variables (or intervening factors—e.g., smartphone addiction, engagement by contributing, engagement by consuming), or moderating variables (or influencing factors—e.g., type of mobile app: hedonic versus utilitarian), wherein their status as variables (independent, dependent, mediating, moderating) emerges only when they are linked, manipulated, and tested—otherwise, they remain as constructs (measured), distinct from concepts (unmeasured).

The distinction between concepts, constructs, and variables is crucial (Fig. 1 Panel C). To put it simply:

- A *concept* names and defines a phenomenon to give it meaning. This means a concept is only an abstract idea—not yet operationalized or verified. Hence, a concept is a concept because it clarifies what we *mean* (concept), not how we *measure* (construct) or *manipulate* and *test* (variable).
- A *construct* specifies a concept in measurable terms for empirical use. This means a construct is derived from a concept and made measurable for research. Hence, a construct is a construct because it turns meaning into something we can *observe* and *quantify*—without requiring it to vary.
- A *variable* captures how a construct changes to test its effect on another. This means a variable only makes sense when it *varies* across observations—without variability, analysis is impossible. Hence, a variable is a variable because it must vary to enable analysis.

Conceptualization happens at two levels: concepts and relationships. Operationalization also occurs at two levels: constructs and variables. This equivalence ensures that the abstract components of the theory are systematically translated into measurable, manipulable, and testable elements to facilitate rigorous scientific investigation. Clearly defining, linking, measuring, manipulating, and testing these elements thus enable scholars to explain and empirically support their theories. This structured approach not only enhances the clarity and precision of the theory but also its utility in guiding research and practice.

In addition to being conceptualizable and operationalizable, a good theory also needs to exhibit *generalizability*, *extendibility*, and *falsifiability* (Fig. 1 Panel B).

Generalizability is about whether a theory can be applied across different situations. For example, Moriuchi et al. (2025) looked into whether the idea that engagement varies—that different types of engagement can either help or not help in reducing the impact of smartphone addiction on wellbeing—holds up across various types of mobile apps by comparing fun apps (hedonic) with practical ones (utilitarian). In this regard, showing generalizability means that the fundamental ideas of the theory stay relevant outside of where they were initially created. This matters because it indicates that the theory is not limited to a single context but can be applied broadly and provide valuable insights in many scenarios, which, in turn, makes it more useful

⁶ Abstraction and assumption are common terms in theory development (Bacharach, 1989; Dubin, 1978; Jaccard & Jacoby, 2020), where the 5W1H framework of what, where, when, who, why, and how serves as the building blocks of this process (Whetten, 1989).

⁷ Here, “who” refers to the “unit of analysis” (e.g., individuals, dyads, teams, departments, subsidiaries, firms, networks, industries, cities, countries, regions), which is important because it sets the level at which the theory operates, shapes the boundaries of generalizability, and guides the design of empirical tests (see Lorenzoni & Ferriani, 2008).

and relevant in practice (Homer & Lim, 2024).

Extendibility is about how well a theory can adapt, evolve, and by extension, incorporate new discoveries or insights as they emerge, which, in turn, allows the theory to remain useful and relevant over time. A good illustration of extendibility is how Moriuchi et al. (2025) took Muntinga et al.'s (2011) original idea—engagement by consuming versus contributing content in consumers' online brand-related activities (COBRAs)—and innovatively extended it to a completely different context, specifically showing how active versus passive app engagement might mitigate smartphone addiction's harmful effects on overall wellbeing.

Falsifiability is about a theory's capacity to withstand rigorous empirical scrutiny and systematic attempts at disconfirmation (Aguinis & Cronin, 2025), meaning that the theory's predictions can be tested and shown clearly as correct or incorrect through empirical evidence. For instance, in experimental research, conducting manipulation checks and follow-up studies designed specifically to not only confirm that the intended manipulation was successfully implemented (i.e., participants perceived the conditions as theorized) but also rule out confounding variables (i.e., extraneous factors that can produce a false appearance of causation, or in other words, spurious causes) exemplifies the principle of falsifiability by ensuring that observed effects are genuinely attributable to the theorized concepts and relationships rather than alternative explanations (Viglia et al., 2021). Importantly, falsification does not always indicate theoretical weakness or failure, rather, when aspects of a theory are not supported as initially predicted, this can highlight areas for theoretical refinement or provide opportunities for discovering new theoretical insights, thereby making a significant contribution to theory development. To illustrate, Moriuchi et al. (2025) conducted two studies, the second of which specifically tested whether engagement-based contributing and consuming behaviors have distinct effects on wellbeing across hedonic versus utilitarian apps. They confirmed that contributing behavior significantly enhances wellbeing for hedonic apps but falsified their prediction regarding consuming behavior, revealing that consuming behavior, unexpectedly, significantly improved

wellbeing for utilitarian apps. This falsification, in turn, provided novel theoretical insights by highlighting distinct engagement mechanisms through which different app types influence wellbeing.

Generalizability, extendibility, and falsifiability form an interconnected system, wherein theories must be broadly applicable, dynamically adaptable to new discoveries, and robustly testable to withstand empirical scrutiny. Collectively, they ensure a theory's ongoing relevance and utility in evolving real-world phenomena that theory endeavors to comprehend, explain, and predict.

To this end, a *good* theory is, therefore, one that is *rigorously* developed both conceptually and operationally, as well as one that is *robustly* demonstrated through generalizability, extendibility, and falsifiability. This approach ensures that the theory not only provides thorough insights but also withstands the test of time and varied applications, thereby contributing meaningfully to the (continued) advancement of knowledge.

2.2. Typology of theory

A typology of theory is introduced to encompass various types based on the complexity and scope of concepts and their (inter)relationships. This typology does not indicate which type of theory is more important or valuable, rather, it provides a means for scholars to define the type of theory they are focusing on or developing. Theories can be classified into those focusing on a *single element*, such as *concept theory* and *relationship theory*, and those addressing *multiple elements*, such as *typology theory*, *framework (or model) theory*, and *integrated (or hybrid) theory* (Fig. 2). Theories focusing on single elements build a foundational understanding of specific concepts and their immediate relationships while those addressing multiple elements offer wider perspectives by examining complex interrelationships. This typology enables scholars to organize information, identify patterns, and develop comprehensive views of phenomena, thereby enhancing the rigor and relevance of scholarly research by ensuring that theories are both applicable and adaptable to a wide range of contexts.

Panel A. Principles of a theory

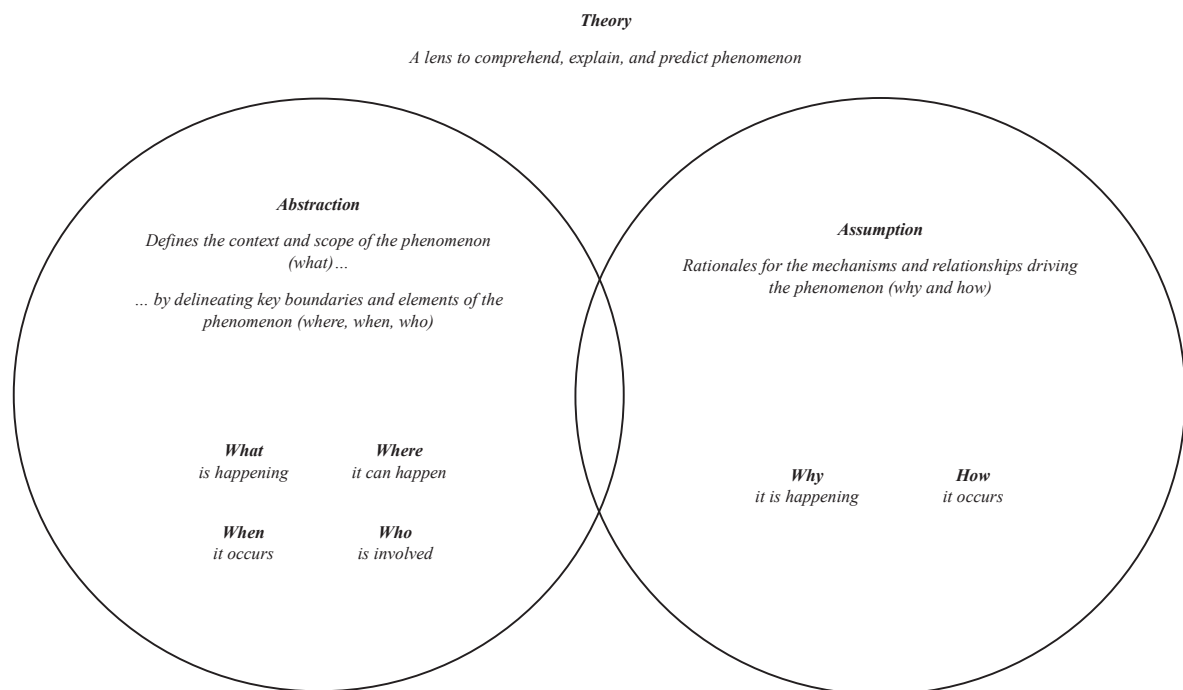


Fig. 1. A (good) theory Panel A. Principles of a theory Panel B. Principles of a good theory Panel C. Distinction between conceptualization (concept, relationship) and operationalization (construct, variable).

Panel B. Principles of a good theory

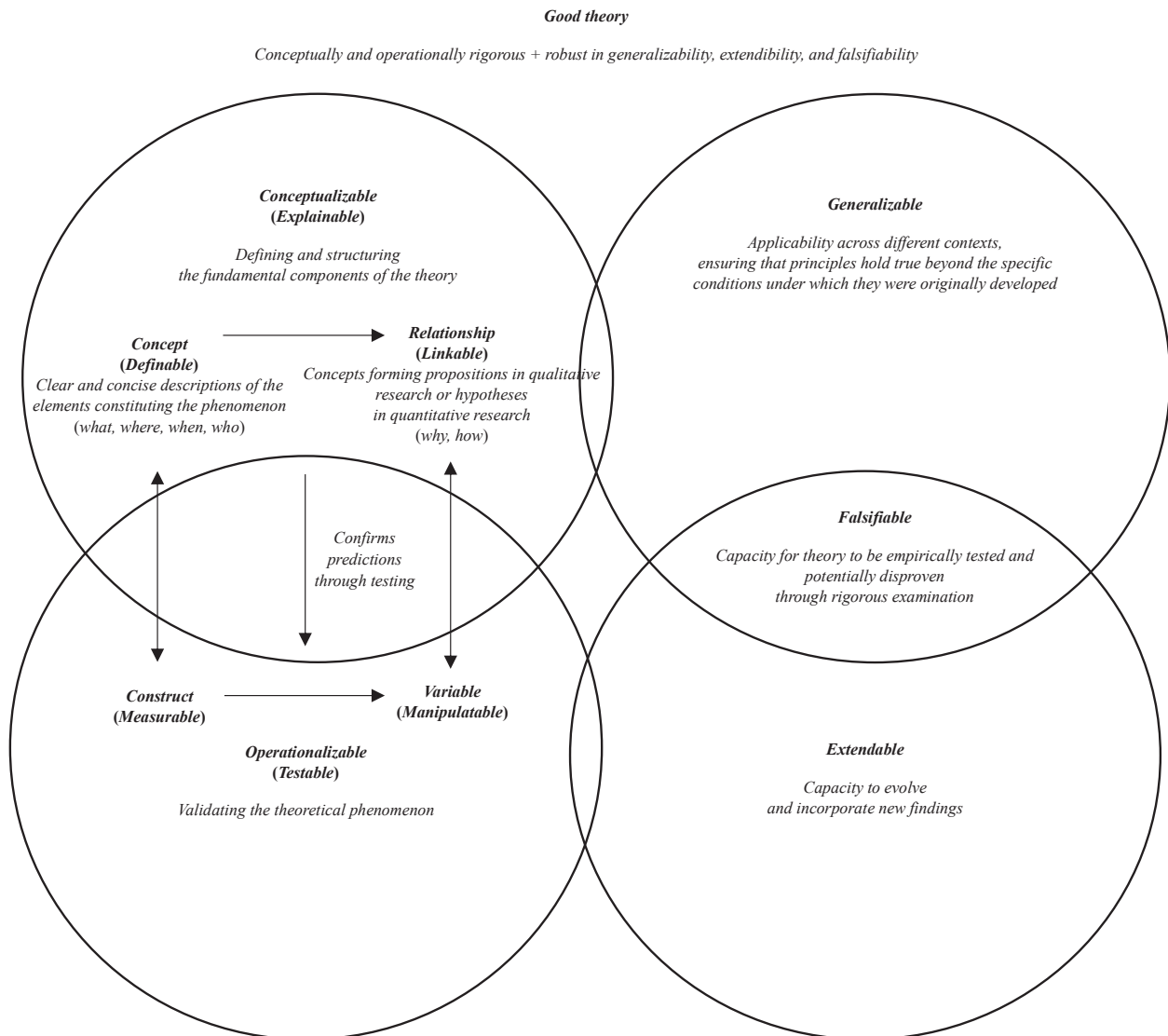
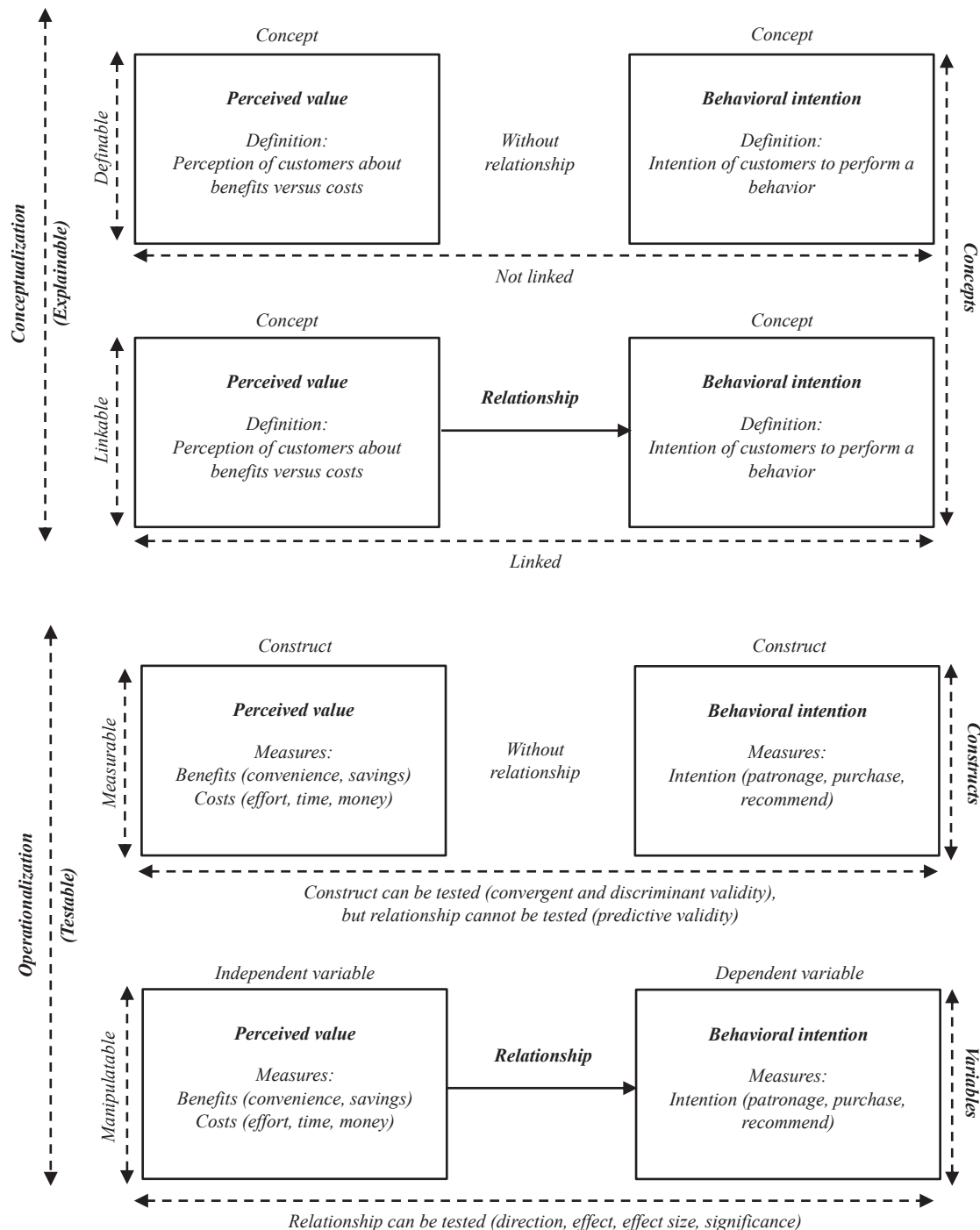


Fig. 1. (continued).

Panel C. Distinction between conceptualization (concept, relationship) and operationalization (construct, variable)**Fig. 1.** (continued).

2.2.1. Concept theory: A theory of concept

Concept theory focuses on defining and understanding individual concepts within a specific domain. This approach involves a deep exploration of a single concept by providing a detailed understanding of its attributes, dimensions, and boundaries. For instance, a concept theory might explore the concept of "customer brand engagement" by examining its various dimensions such as customers' cognitive, affective, and behavioral engagement with brands (Hollebeek, 2011). The work of Lewis et al. (2023) is another example of concept theory, as it

concentrates on unpacking the concept of health equity, wherein the authors clarify the boundaries and dimensions of what "health equity" means in healthcare, distinguishing it from related concepts like "health disparity." Isolating and scrutinizing a single concept thus allow scholars to develop a thorough and precise understanding, which can then serve as a foundation for further theoretical development and empirical testing. This focused approach ensures clarity and depth in comprehending the core elements of the concept and thus facilitating more accurate and meaningful research outcomes.

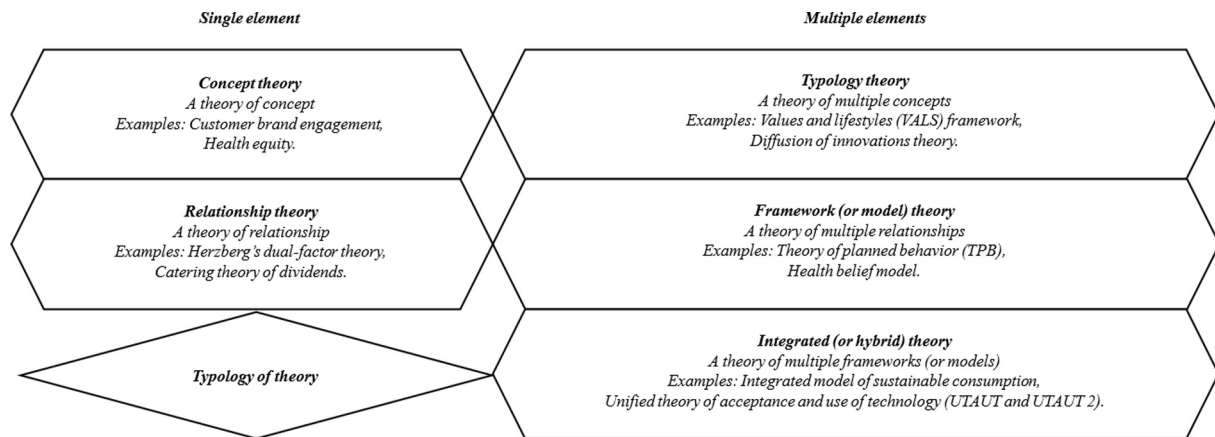


Fig. 2. A typology of theory.

2.2.2. Relationship theory: A theory of relationship

Relationship theory examines the direct relationships between two or more concepts and thus seeks to understand how different concepts interact and influence each other, which, in turn, forms the basis for correlational or causal relationships. For instance, Herzberg's dual-factor theory from organizational psychology can be adopted or adapted to investigate the relationship between motivation and satisfaction. The theory posits that factors leading to satisfaction (motivators) and factors leading to dissatisfaction (hygiene factors) directly affect overall motivation and satisfaction (Herzberg et al., 1959). Baker and Wurgler's (2004) catering theory of dividends is another example from finance that proposes a direct relationship between investor sentiment and dividend issuance, with managers' behavior responding to investor demand, and thus exemplifies a prototypical relationship theory. Relationship theory is thus crucial for identifying and explaining the dynamics between key concepts, providing insights into how changes in one concept can affect another. Understanding these relationships helps in designing interventions and strategies to enhance desired outcomes, such as increasing salesperson productivity by improving job satisfaction or strengthening customer loyalty by improving service quality.

2.2.3. Typology theory: A theory of multiple concepts

Typology theory involves the classification of multiple concepts into distinct categories or types, thus providing a structured framework for comparing and contrasting different concepts. This approach facilitates a comprehensive understanding of the domain by organizing complex information into a coherent structure. For instance, in marketing, the values and lifestyles (VALS) framework—a segmentation theory—is regarded as a typology theory that classifies consumers into eight distinct types (innovators, thinkers, believers, achievers, strivers, experiencers, makers, survivors) based on two dimensions: primary motivations and resources (Strategic Business Insights, 2024). The first dimension, primary motivation, captures consumers' core motivations: ideals, achievement, and self-expression. The second dimension, resources, includes factors such as education, energy, income, intelligence, leadership skills, and self-confidence. Originally developed to understand societal changes, the VALS framework has evolved into a crucial marketing tool that explains consumer behavior (e.g., media consumption; Valentine & Powers, 2013). Similarly, Rogers's (1962) diffusion of innovations theory from information technology exemplifies another typology theory that segments individuals into five adopter categories according to their innovativeness or how quickly they adopt new ideas relative to others: innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority, and laggards. This structured typology illuminates differences in how these categories respond to innovations over time and provides a framework that has guided theoretical and empirical work on diffusion patterns across domains such as agriculture, fashion, and finance. For

instance, Ayisi et al. (2022) explicitly classifies farmers into Rogers' five adopter categories (from innovators to laggards) and finds, for example, that over one-third are late majority adopters, with more than 75 % categorized as low-innovators, thereby highlighting heterogeneity in farmer innovativeness and its socioeconomic determinants. Likewise, Okur (2022) employs Rogers' diffusion of innovations theory by segmenting fashion consumers into the standard adopter groups (i.e., innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority, laggards) using an innovativeness scale and then analyzes how each segment's perceptions of fast-fashion and motivational drivers (e.g., desire for conformity or uniqueness) differ across the adoption spectrum. Similarly, Rzayev et al. (2025) partition cryptocurrency users into Rogers' adopter categories, specifically innovators (early adopters) versus imitators (late adopters), to examine how each group's adoption timing differentially influences market dynamics and pricing efficiency. Organizing concepts into categories thus helps scholars identify patterns and relationships among various elements and, in turn, enhances their ability to generate and test new hypotheses. Specifically, this structured approach aids in understanding the characteristics of the domain and provides a solid foundation for further theoretical development and empirical investigation. In other words, typology theory's ability to classify and systematize complex concepts makes it invaluable for developing comprehensive views of phenomena and advancing knowledge in a structured and meaningful way.

2.2.4. Framework (or model) theory: A theory of multiple relationships

Framework (or model) theory addresses multiple relationships among concepts, including main (direct) relationships, mediation (indirect, conditional) relationships, and moderation (conditional) relationships, as well as more complex variants such as moderated mediation and serial mediation. This type of theory offers a holistic view of how various factors interact, thereby providing a comprehensive and detailed explanation of phenomena. The theory of planned behavior exemplifies a framework theory by examining the relationships between attitudes, subjective norms, perceived behavioral control, and behavioral intentions, which, in turn, predict actual behavior (Ajzen, 1991). In this theory, an individual's attitude toward a behavior directly influences their intention to perform the behavior. Subjective norms, or the perceived social pressure to engage in the behavior, also directly affect behavioral intentions. Perceived behavioral control, which refers to the perceived ease or difficulty of performing the behavior, influences both the intention and the actual behavior. Intention serves as a mediator between attitude and behavior, indicating that attitude affects behavior through its impact on intention. Perceived behavioral control acts as a moderator, potentially strengthening or weakening the relationship between intention and behavior, often explaining the intention-behavior gap. This framework captures the complexity of consumer

decision-making processes and thus enhances the explanatory power and predictive accuracy of the theory. Understanding these relationships also helps marketers identify leverage points for influencing consumer behavior, thereby optimizing marketing efforts. Noteworthy, the behavioral lens offered by the theory of planned behavior is not limited to psychology or marketing, as it transcends across many core disciplines like ethics and management, as well as applied disciplines such as education and tourism. For instance, Black et al. (2022) applied the theory of planned behavior to workplace ethics by showing that adding moral disengagement to the theory helps predict employees' ethical intentions, as moral disengagement influences attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control, which, in turn, shape ethical decision-making intentions. Likewise, Voet and De Wever (2020) employed the theory of planned behavior to examine teachers' curriculum planning decisions, revealing that teachers' attitudes toward the goals and perceived behavioral control over achieving them significantly predict how teachers prioritize and allocate attention to instructional goals in the classroom. Similarly, Erul et al. (2020) integrated the theory of planned behavior with emotional solidarity, as seen in residents' emotional bonds with tourists, to predict residents' support for tourism, showing that the attitude toward tourism, subjective norms, and perceived control, together with residents' emotional solidarity, explained a large portion of their intentions to support local tourism development.

The health belief model is another illustrative example of framework theory that, unlike most theories that emerged from academia, originated from practice via the U.S. Public Health Service, and is widely used in healthcare research, as it connects multiple concepts into a coherent explanation of health behavior (Janz & Becker, 1984). This model posits that perceived susceptibility, indicating the risk of contracting a health issue, and perceived severity, indicating the seriousness of the health issue, combine to create a perceived threat that motivates individuals to consider taking action. This perceived threat interacts with perceived benefits, indicating the effectiveness of taking preventive action, and perceived barriers, indicating the costs or obstacles to taking action, which, together, determine the likelihood of adopting a health behavior. Cues to action, which can be internal (symptoms) or external (reminders), trigger the decision-making process leading to action. Self-efficacy, which pertains to confidence in one's ability to execute the behavior, influences whether individuals feel capable of performing the recommended health behavior, often moderating the strength of the relationship between intention and actual behavior. This structured interrelationship among concepts enables healthcare professionals to design targeted interventions that effectively promote preventive health behaviors. Hence, framework theories like the theory of planned behavior and health belief model demonstrate the value of addressing multiple relationships in a structured manner, thereby enabling scholars to develop models that capture the dynamics of real-world phenomena and contribute significantly to the advancement of knowledge and practice.

2.2.5. Integrated (or hybrid) theory: A theory of multiple frameworks (or models)

Integrated (or hybrid) theory combines multiple frameworks (or models) to provide a comprehensive understanding of complex phenomena. This approach synthesizes different theoretical perspectives to offer a more complete and multifaceted explanation. For instance, the integrated model of sustainable consumption is an example of integrated (or hybrid) theory that combines various theories where consumer behavior and sustainability intersect, including anti-consumption, mindful consumption, and responsible consumption (encompassing ethical consumption, environmentally-friendly, green, organic, or pro-environmental consumption, and socially-responsible consumption) (Lim, 2017). In another instance, the second version of the unified theory of acceptance and use of technology (UTAUT2) exemplifies an integrated theory that combines elements from the original UTAUT

(performance expectancy, effort expectancy, social influence, and facilitating conditions) with constructs from other theories—namely, hedonic motivation from motivation theory, price value from marketing theory, and habit from psychology theory—to provide a comprehensive view of how consumers adopt and use technology (Venkatesh et al., 2012). The original UTAUT focuses on organizational contexts (Venkatesh et al., 2003), whereas UTAUT2 extends this to consumer settings (Venkatesh et al., 2012), highlighting the appropriate contexts for their use, and by extension, the potential for context to also contribute to theory development (Homer & Lim, 2024; Venkatesh, 2025). Noteworthy, integrated theories like the integrated model of sustainable consumption, UTAUT, and UTAUT2 are often easier to create as they draw on established frameworks, but they can be difficult to extend due to the complexity and potential conflicts between underlying assumptions. More importantly, integrating multiple frameworks (or models) allows scholars to address complex research questions that cannot be adequately explained by a single theory, thereby advancing the depth and breadth of scholarly inquiry. This integrated approach, which has been called for by various scholars (Calder et al., 2023), offers a richer understanding of phenomena and thus returns a greater extent of valuable insights that contribute to both theory and practice. Therefore, scholars must carefully consider the compatibility and fit of the combined theories to ensure a coherent and effective integrated framework (or model).⁸

3. What are theoretical gaps and how to locate and problematize them?

Unlike practical gaps, which may relate to the lack of knowledge, skills, policy, resource, and technology (Lim and Bowman, 2023), theoretical gaps are voids in literature where certain aspects of a phenomenon remain *unexplored* due to the *absence of research attention*, *underdeveloped* due to *insufficient theoretical maturity* or *limited empirical validation*, or *uncertain* due to *conflicting or inconsistent findings*. Spotting these gaps—i.e., the 3Us of unexplored, underdeveloped, or uncertain areas—is crucial for advancing knowledge and guiding future research endeavors (Fig. 3).

Unexplored areas are aspects of a phenomenon that have not received attention in existing research. These gaps might arise from *emerging topics* and *unexplored contexts*. The novelty of the subject or its peripheral status in the discipline often leads to such unexplored areas due to the absence of research attention.⁹ For example, biodiversity finance remains largely unexplored in sustainable finance research. Despite growing recognition of biodiversity risks, theoretical frameworks explicitly connecting financial practices with biodiversity outcomes remain scarce, signaling a significant void in this critical sustainability domain (Jonäll et al., 2025).

Underdeveloped areas encapsulate aspects of a phenomenon that, while recognized in literature, have not been sufficiently developed in terms of theoretical maturity or empirical validation. These gaps might result from overlooked dimensions of phenomena (e.g., inadequate theoretical frameworks, incomplete models) or lack of empirical testing. Insufficient theoretical maturity often stems from initial exploratory studies that have not been followed up with more rigorous theoretical work, whereas empirical validation may be lacking due to methodological limitations or resource constraints. For instance, the notion of “wicked problems” in

⁸ See the 7Cs framework by Hollebeek et al. (2024) and the IMPACT framework by Hollebeek et al. (2025).

⁹ Here, *disciplinary(ity)* (single-field focus), *multidisciplinary(ity)* (juxtaposing multiple fields without integrating them), *interdisciplinary(ity)* (integrating insights across fields), and *transdisciplinary(ity)* (transcending and co-creating knowledge beyond established disciplines) perspectives each influence which topics are viewed as peripheral or novel, thereby shaping the emergence of research gaps (see Alvargonzález, 2011).

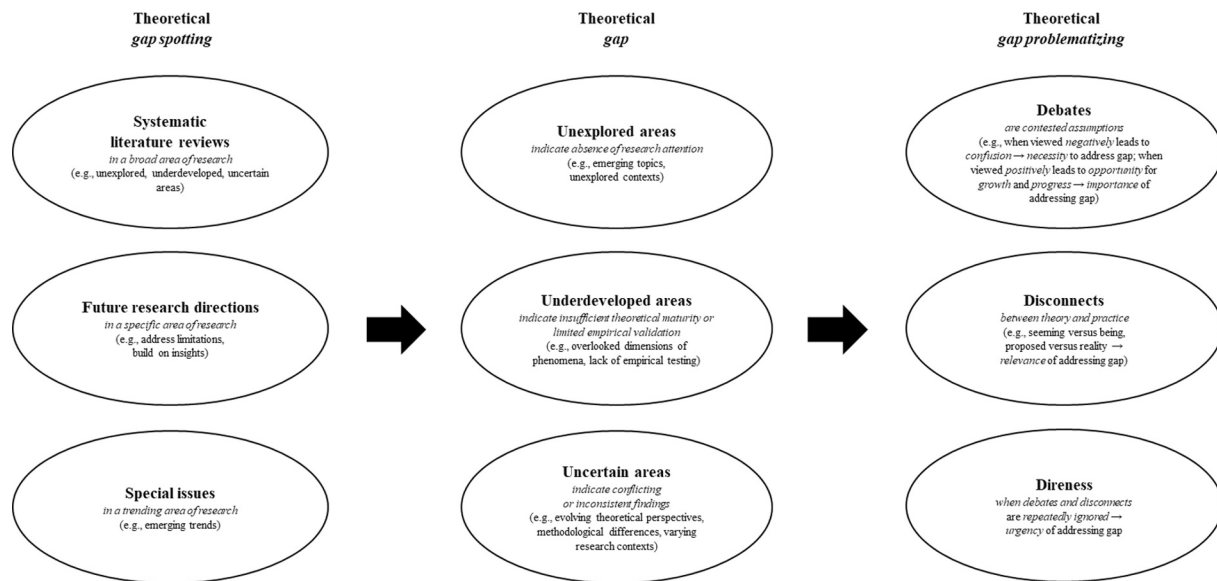


Fig. 3. Typology of theoretical gap spotting, theoretical gap, and theoretical gap problematizing.

sustainability management is frequently acknowledged yet remains theoretically underdeveloped (George et al., 2016). Despite numerous references to sustainability as a wicked problem, there is limited conceptual agreement and rigorous empirical validation regarding what precisely constitutes wickedness in sustainability management, resulting in fragmented frameworks and incomplete theoretical development (Lönngren & Van Poeck, 2021).

Uncertain areas involve aspects of a phenomenon where existing research presents conflicting or inconsistent findings (Higgins and Thompson, 2002). Such gaps indicate a lack of clarity or consensus in literature, often due to evolving theoretical perspectives, methodological differences, or varying research contexts. These conflicting or inconsistent findings, in turn, necessitate further investigation to resolve ambiguities and build a more coherent body of knowledge. An illustrative example is the debate over behavioral spillover effects in sustainable consumer behavior research. While some studies report positive spillover, suggesting one sustainable action leads to further pro-environmental or pro-social behaviors, others have found negative spillover (moral licensing), where initial sustainability actions decrease the likelihood of subsequent pro-environmental or pro-social behaviors—an inconsistency that underscores significant uncertainty in understanding consumer sustainability practices (Behn et al., 2025).

Locating theoretical gaps requires a strategic approach to reviewing existing literature. *Systematic literature reviews* offer a comprehensive overview of existing research and provide valuable insights into unexplored, underdeveloped, or uncertain areas (Lim et al., 2022). *Future research directions* in recent publications also pinpoint areas where further research is needed, albeit more narrowly than systematic literature reviews as the focus of these directions is to address the limitations or build on the insights from such publications. *Special issues* in scholarly journals, which, by nature, are future-oriented, often highlight emerging trends where research is required.

Spotting theoretical gaps alone, however, is inadequate. This means that knowing that a gap exists does not mean that the gap should be addressed. Instead, gaps, after being identified, need to be problematized. To do so, scholars must invest intellectual effort to convincingly unpack the “so what” of addressing gaps—including but also going beyond whether these gaps emerge due to neglect (e.g., unexplored or underdeveloped) or missed opportunities (e.g., to complement or extend understanding, to reconcile competing explanations) (Sandberg & Alvesson, 2011). As Alvesson and Sandberg (2020, p. 1290) explained, “problematizing [is] an ‘opening up exercise’ that enables [scholars] to

imagine how to rethink existing ways to generate new and ‘better’ ways of thinking about specific phenomena,” which Davis (1971) add should “challenge [the] status quo,” and thus, can manifest in three forms that is conceptualized herein as debates, disconnects, and direness:

- *Debates* are contested assumptions, which, when viewed negatively, lead to confusion, thereby highlighting the necessity to address the gap, or when viewed positively, signal an opportunity for growth and progress, thereby underscoring the importance of addressing the gap (e.g., recent research demonstrating that reduced income inequality lowers environmental emissions only in wealthy countries, whereas greater inequality correlates with lower emissions in lower-income countries, challenging widely held assumptions linking equality and sustainability; Nicolli et al., 2025).
- *Disconnects* between theory and practice—in terms of seeming versus being or proposed versus reality—thereby highlighting the relevance of addressing the gap (e.g., more problems of unsustainable consumption and production despite more theoretical and practical efforts to promote sustainability; Lim, 2022).
- *Direness* arises when debates and disconnects are repeatedly ignored, thereby signaling the urgency to address the gap (e.g., the “elephant in the room” in sustainability is that mainstream consumers and firms prioritize economic goals over environmental and social ones, and amid worsening challenges like climate change, inequality, and poverty, new ways of thinking are therefore needed to confront this reality; Lim, 2022).

Why do we need both theoretical gap spotting and problematizing? The answer is simple: a gap without a problem has no meaning while a problem without a gap has no novelty. To elaborate, spotting a theoretical gap specifies what remains unexplored, underdeveloped, or uncertain in the existing literature (novelty). Problematization then frames why that missing piece matters (meaning)—what tension it creates (necessity), what consequences hinge on resolving it (importance), who cares about it (relevance), and how fast we need answers (urgency). Hence, when taken together, they provide both novelty (the gap) and meaning (the problem). This complementary perspective, in turn, resolves the existing debate driven by the competing perspective between those emphasizing gaps and those emphasizing problematization (see Sandberg & Alvesson, 2011) by showing that both are interdependent rather than mutually exclusive. Hence, the problematization of theoretical gaps in such a manner—i.e., debates, disconnects, and direness—is what makes

Table 2

Five questions to ask for developing strong theoretical foundations.

Questions	Answers	Examples
What is (are) the focal theory(ies)?	Identify the primary theories that directly inform and underpin the study.	Introduce theories relevant to the research questions or objectives, such as the theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1991) and theory of behavioral control (Lim & Weissmann, 2023) for understanding the intention–behavior gap in (un)sustainable consumption.
Why is (are) the focal theory(ies) important?	Explain how the chosen theories provide an appropriate and relevant lens for addressing the research questions or objectives.	Highlight the robustness of the theory of planned behavior for predicting behavioral intentions and the theory of behavioral control for its finer-grained understanding of behavioral control.
How have existing studies used the focal theory(ies)?	Review how previous research has applied the theories, what findings have been derived, and what methodologies have been used.	Conduct a strategic literature review showing the versatility of the theory of planned behavior across different contexts and revealing the newness of the theory of behavioral control.
How is the present study using the focal theory(ies)?	Detail the specific aspects of the theories being utilized, the propositions or hypotheses tested, and the methodological approaches employed.	Use the theory of behavioral control to explore (qualitative: interviews → content analysis) and examine (quantitative: survey → structural equation modeling) how controls influence intention and behavior.
How is the present study contributing back to the focal theory(ies)?	Demonstrate how the findings affirm, extend, refine, challenge, or even refute the focal theories, and articulate these contributions.	Identify new factors constituting behavioral control, extending the theory and providing new avenues for future research.

Notes: Countercheck with the IMPACT framework: *interestingness* (selecting theories that challenge or extend prevailing understanding), *matching* (ensuring a strong theoretical alignment or co-infusion between the selected theory and the focal concepts and relationships), *parsimony* (choosing theories that sufficiently explain phenomena using the simplest possible assumptions and concepts without sacrificing explanatory power), *applicability* (prioritizing theories that produce insights with clear managerial or practical relevance), *conceptual rigor* (selecting and applying theories with clear definitions, logical coherence, well-articulated boundaries, and systematic relationships), and *testability* (favoring theories that can generate propositions or hypotheses capable of empirical verification or falsification) (Hollebeek et al., 2025).

theory development endeavors truly meaningful and thus sets up such endeavors to deliver truly valuable insights that guide future efforts. This strategic approach, in turn, ensures that scholarly research remains relevant, rigorous, and impactful.

4. What are theoretical foundations and how to write about them?

Theoretical foundations set the scene for making significant theoretical contributions. They provide the necessary framework within which new research can be situated, thereby ensuring that the study is anchored in established knowledge. The strength of these foundations lies in their ability to justify and support the research questions or objectives, propositions or hypotheses, and methodologies employed. The core of the theoretical foundations is the focal theory or theories that guide the study. Developing strong theoretical foundations involves addressing several key questions, as indicated by Lim et al. (2022), which are elaborated below and summarized in Table 2.

What is (are) the focal theory(ies)? Identifying the focal theory(ies) is the first step in establishing a strong theoretical foundation. These are the primary theories that directly inform and underpin the study. Focal theories provide the theoretical framework that shapes the study's direction and focus, including the selection of concepts (constructs, variables). They are chosen based on their relevance to the research questions or objectives.¹⁰ For example, if the study examines the reasons for (un)sustainable consumption, theories such as the theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1991) and the theory of behavioral control (Lim & Weissmann, 2023) might be selected as focal theories.

Why is (are) the focal theory(ies) important? Clearly explaining why focal theories matter is the next critical step. This involves demonstrating how the chosen theories provide an appropriate and relevant lens to address the research questions or objectives. The importance of the focal theories can be justified in several ways, including their established credibility (e.g., the theory of planned behavior's widespread acceptance across behavioral research; Ajzen, 2020), the extent of their empirical validation (e.g., widespread empirical testing and replication across contexts; Fishbein & Ajzen, 2010), and their potential ability to address the specific phenomena under investigation (e.g., accurately predicting individual intentions and behaviors across diverse settings; Armitage & Conner, 2001). In this regard, highlighting the theoretical and practical relevance of the focal theories helps to establish their importance and sets the stage for their application in the study. For instance, the theory of planned behavior is widely recognized for its role in providing a strong foundation for accommodating extensions and predicting behavioral intentions (Ajzen, 2020) while the theory of behavioral control expands on this by establishing covert (internal) and overt (external) controls to strengthen the prediction of behavioral intentions and their translation into actual behavior, thereby offering a finer-grained understanding of how behavior is regulated (Lim & Weissmann, 2023).

How have existing studies used the focal theory(ies)? The next step is to review how existing studies have utilized the focal theories in order to provide insights into their application and effectiveness. To do so, a strategic literature review is conducted to showcase how previous research has applied these theories, what findings have been derived, and what methodological approaches have been employed. This step may include presenting key literature in a table accompanied by relevant narrative descriptions (see Table 1 herein or a similar table in Lim & Weissmann, 2023). In doing so, understanding the historical and contemporary use of the focal theories helps identify gaps, limitations, and opportunities for further research. This also ensures that the new study builds on and contributes to the existing body of knowledge. For example, existing studies may have used the theory of planned behavior to examine various consumer behaviors, highlighting its versatility and relevance across different contexts (Ajzen, 2020). However, the lack of usage of the theory of behavioral control, due to its newness, provides a good opportunity to explore an underdeveloped area of literature. This exploration can shed light on how the intention–behavior gap for (un)sustainable consumption can be closed (or opened) based on an investigation of covert and overt behavioral controls (Lim & Weissmann,

¹⁰ Comparing and contrasting the chosen theory(ies) against other candidate theories can further strengthen the case for their selection by highlighting their superior explanatory power (ability) and fit (coherence) with the phenomenon under study. For example, the choice of uncanny valley theory (which posits that near-human likeness in an agent elicits a simultaneous sense of attraction and unease) as opposed to algorithm aversion theory (which describes users' generalized reluctance to trust algorithmic outputs after perceived errors) to support theoretical scrutiny of the role of anthropomorphism in generative artificial intelligence (AI) like OpenAI's ChatGPT is justified because uncanny valley theory directly captures the emotional dynamics of engaging with an almost-human AI (Mori, 1970), whereas algorithm aversion theory focuses more narrowly on post-error trust judgments rather than in-the-moment affective responses (Dietvorst et al., 2015).

2023).

How is the present study using the focal theory(ies)? Clearly articulating how the present study is applying the focal theory or theories is essential. This involves detailing the specific aspects of the theories that are being utilized and how they inform the propositions or hypotheses that are being tested. Noteworthy, explaining the alignment between the research questions or objectives and the theoretical framework helps to demonstrate the coherence and rigor of the study. This also provides a clear rationale for the chosen concepts (constructs, variables), research design (e.g., qualitative, quantitative), and methods (e.g., interviews, surveys; content analysis, structural equation modeling). For instance, a new study might apply the theory of behavioral control (Lim & Weissmann, 2023) to explore (qualitative: interviews → content analysis) and examine (quantitative: survey → structural equation modeling) how both covert and overt controls influence the intention and behavior relationship in (un)sustainable consumption as per the theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1991).

How is the present study contributing back to the focal theory(ies)? Integrating focal theories into research offers the opportunity to contribute back to the theories that underpin the study. This involves demonstrating how the findings of the study affirm, extend, refine, challenge, or even refute the focal theories. Contributions can take various forms, such as providing empirical validation, identifying boundary conditions, proposing modifications or extensions, or offering new insights that enhance the theoretical understanding of the phenomenon under study. Clearly articulating these contributions is critical for demonstrating the value and impact of the study. For instance, a new study might identify new factors that constitute behavioral control, thereby extending the theory and offering new avenues for future research.

As a countercheck to ensure that the chosen focal theories are not only suitable but also capable of delivering meaningful research impact, scholars can employ the IMPACT framework proposed by Hollebeek et al. (2025). Specifically, scholars should select theories that demonstrate *interestingness* (challenging or extending existing theoretical assumptions or insights to yield novel understandings), establish clear *matching* (ensuring a strong theoretical alignment or co-infusion between the selected theory and the focal concepts and relationships), pursue balanced *parsimony* (opting for theories that concisely yet sufficiently explain the phenomena of interest without redundant or unnecessary complexity), demonstrate practical *applicability* (generating insights that are explicitly relevant and actionable for practitioners, policymakers, or society), uphold strong *conceptual rigor* (using theories characterized by clear definitions, coherent logic, well-articulated scope, and systematic relationships among concepts), and finally, enable clear *testability* (capable of empirically verifying or falsifying derived propositions or hypotheses through rigorous research methods). Employing this comprehensive, explicit, and structured approach as a quality check ensures that focal theories adopted not only provide strong theoretical foundations but also significantly contribute to both theoretical advancement and practical application (Hollebeek et al., 2025).

5. What are theoretical contributions and how to pursue them?

Theoretical contributions are made when research, with strong theoretical foundations,¹¹ *contributes to theory development*. The saying, “Nothing is as practical as a good theory” (Greenwood & Levin, 1998; Yorks, 2005), implies that a good theory provides valuable insights and guidance that can be applied to comprehend, explain, and predict reality, and in doing so, potentially solve real-world problems. Hence, in the endeavor to make theoretical contributions, it is important to set the

scene by showing the practical and theoretical gaps.

Setting the scene by showing practical gaps involves addressing several key aspects: necessity, importance, relevance, and urgency (Lim et al., 2022). *Necessity* refers to the essential need for research to address a significant issue that has not yet been resolved. For instance, consumption has risen to a tipping point, depleting natural resources and causing environmental degradation due to emission and waste (de Zeeuw, 2024). *Importance* highlights the value and impact of the research, emphasizing how it can influence or create change. The environmental issue, for example, presents an opportunity to promote pro-environmental behaviors (Laheer et al., 2024). *Relevance* ensures that the research addresses current and pertinent issues that stakeholders care about, aligning with real-world challenges (threats) and opportunities (prospects). Climate change, flagged as a ‘code red’ crisis for humanity by the United Nations (2021) Secretary-General António Guterres based on the findings of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change Working Group 1 Report on the Physical Science Basis of the Sixth Assessment, demands immediate attention, indicating the relevance and urgency of the research. *Urgency* underscores the timeliness of the research, stressing the need for immediate attention to the issue at hand, such as the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals being on the verge of failure (World Economic Forum, 2023), requiring rapid action. Clearly articulating these practical gaps demonstrates the compelling reasons for the research, thereby establishing a strong foundation for making meaningful and impactful theoretical contributions (Fig. 4 Panel A).

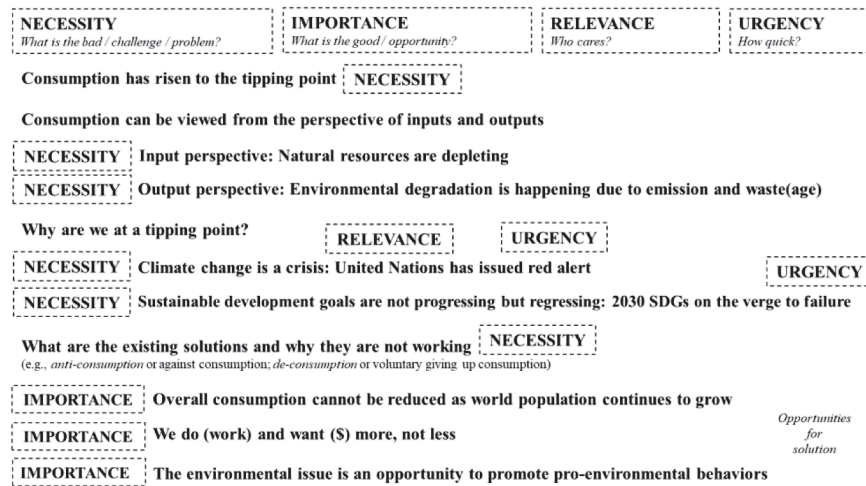
Setting the scene by showing theoretical gaps involves critique and change (Lim, 2023). *Critique* is essential for understanding what is happening by assessing the “what” and “what if.” This involves evaluating both the strengths and weaknesses of existing theories.¹² For example, consumer behavior can be reasoned through the theory of reasoned action (Fishbein & Ajzen, 1975) but the intention-behavior gap highlighted the need for the theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1991). The theory of planned behavior has considerable predictive power (Hrubes et al., 2001) and is parsimonious (Ajzen, 2011), but it also has shortcomings, such as not being contextualized and having limited factors. Yet, opportunities arise from the theory’s parsimony and flexibility, allowing for theoretical extensions and retesting its components, contributing to theoretical generalizability. However, replicating or retesting the theory’s original components without innovation lacks theoretical novelty and using the theory only in its original form may lack theoretical relevance. *Change*, on the other hand, is the act of doing something differently—for example, adapting, modifying, extending, or newly developing—and is necessary to address and respond to critique. Adapting involves fitting an existing to a new context without significant changes. Modifying entails making changes to certain aspects or components to better fit a specific context or purpose. Extending creates an extension of an existing, whereas newly developing involves building something entirely new. However, replicating does not constitute change, as it involves using an existing as is. Importantly, embracing change allows scholars to address the limitations identified through critique and contribute to the evolution and enhancement of theories, ensuring they stay fit for purpose and relevant to contemporary contexts (Fig. 4 Panel B).

Once the practical and theoretical gaps are clarified and well justified, *theory development* can commence. Noteworthy, the extent of theoretical contribution is often guided by *theoretical novelty*, which reflects the *newness of theoretical contributions* (Fig. 4 Panel C). Scholars such as Whetten (1989) and Wen (2025) have emphasized the importance of articulating “what’s new” and Corley and Gioia (2011) have

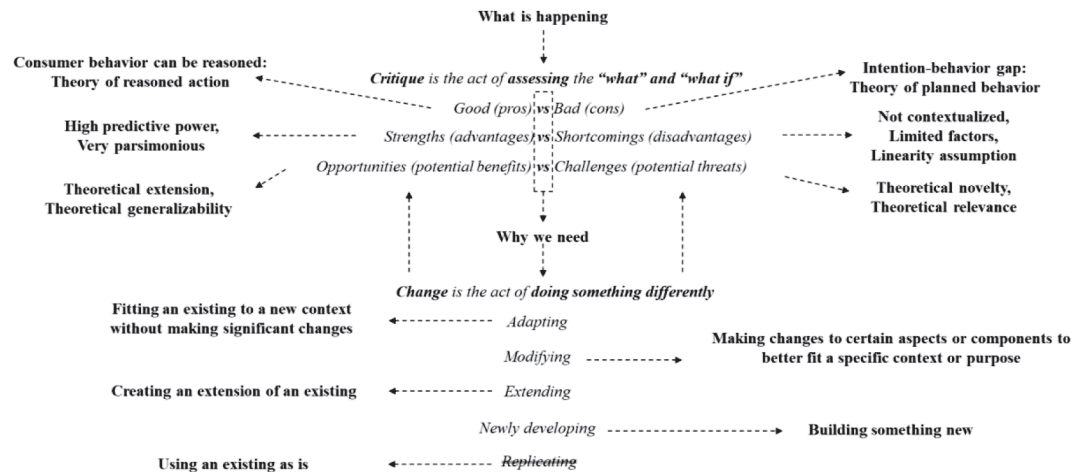
¹¹ Research adopting an inductive approach may be guided by grounded theory (e.g., qualitative research), whereas research taking a deductive approach may be guided by existing theory(ies) (e.g., quantitative research).

¹² The theory of planned behavior exemplifies this process due to its significant impact, having attracted more than 100,000 citations on Google Scholar and contributing to the development of over 10 behavior change theories (Ho et al., 2024; Michie et al., 2014).

Panel A. Setting the scene by showing the practical gaps: Necessity, importance, relevance, and urgency



Panel B. Setting the scene by showing the theoretical gaps: Critique and change



Panel C. Overview of theory development

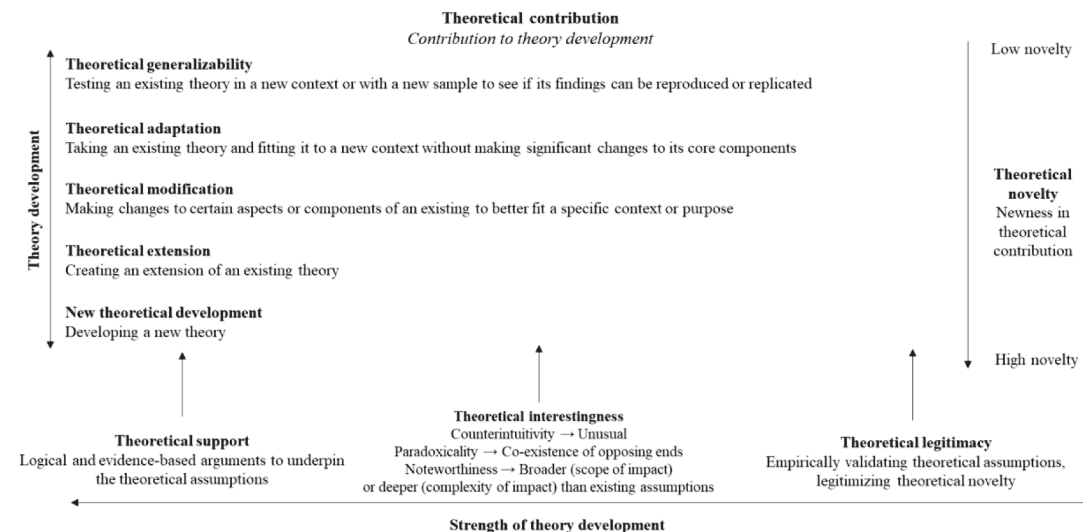


Fig. 4. Making theoretical contributions. Panel A. Setting the scene by showing the practical gaps: Necessity, importance, relevance, and urgency. Panel B. Setting the scene by showing the theoretical gaps: Critique and change. Panel C. Overview of theory development. Panel D. Typology of theoretical contributions. Panel E. Granularity of theoretical relationships. Notes: The theory of reasoned action is developed by Fishbein and Ajzen (1975), the theory of planned behavior by Ajzen (1991), the theory of behavioral control by Lim and Weissmann (2023), and the environmentally conscious theory of planned behavior by Laheri et al. (2024). The figures presented here were deliberately crafted to offer a simple and straightforward representation of theoretical contributions. Although this representation may

initially appear positivistic or post-positivistic because it aligns closely with empirical traditions that emphasize quantitative methods and seek clear, testable causal or correlational relationships, it should not be interpreted as excluding or restricting other paradigmatic and methodological traditions. Indeed, this typology remains highly relevant to constructivist and interpretivist approaches that are typically associated with conceptual, qualitative, and review studies. Arguably, higher degrees of theoretical novelty, particularly those pertaining to theoretical extension and new theoretical development, may be even more naturally suited to conceptual and qualitative research traditions as well as systematic literature reviews that not only describe but also critically synthesize and generate insights in ways that may not be achievable within the confines of a single empirical study. Such methodological approaches often yield richer theoretical explanations encompassing broader and deeper insights, as they commonly adopt a more holistic and systemic perspective to phenomena. In this regard, conceptual, qualitative, and review studies, which approach phenomena holistically and systemically, are especially well-positioned to unpack and illuminate theoretical complexities. Noteworthy, these studies frequently explore complexities that may not be readily measurable or testable within the confines of a single quantitative study. Consequently, while the typology illustrated here may appear visually simplistic and may imply a linear progression of theory building, it does not diminish the applicability or significance of alternative research paradigms and methodologies. Rather, conceptual, qualitative, and review methods inherently facilitate explorations of greater theoretical breadth and depth, thereby making substantive contributions not only to theoretical adaptation, modification, and extension, but especially to the development of novel (new) theoretical frameworks. Scholars are thus encouraged to appreciate this figure as inclusive of diverse paradigmatic and methodological traditions, recognizing that substantial and meaningful theoretical contributions can, and often do, emerge across the spectrum of positivistic, post-positivistic, constructivist, interpretivist, and pragmatist paradigms, as well as conceptual, qualitative, quantitative, and review methodological traditions.

underscored the importance of originality (incremental, revelatory) and utility (practically useful, scientifically useful). Yet, understanding what amounts to theoretical contribution and novelty remains a challenging, if not daunting, task for many scholars (Corley & Schinoff, 2017). This difficulty may stem from the lack of clarity on the extent of *possibilities* for making legitimate theoretical contributions versus the extent of *newness* that such contributions may be expected to bring, depending on the expectations and standings of publication outlets. To address this gap, a typology of theoretical contributions—i.e., theoretical generalizability, theoretical adaptation, theoretical modification, theoretical extension, and new theoretical development—is presented with illustrative exemplars (Fig. 4 Panel D).¹³

Theoretical generalizability involves testing an existing theory in a new context or with a new sample to see if findings can be generalized, or in other words, reusable (Sun et al., 2025). There are two major benefits of theoretical generalizability: theoretical reproducibility and theoretical replicability. *Theoretical reproducibility* demonstrates that a theory is reproducible by supporting existing knowledge in *similar* contexts. For example, applying the theory of planned behavior in its original form across consumption scenarios that are fairly similar, such as green consumption (all-encompassing environment focus), environmentally-friendly consumption (focused on minimizing negative impacts on the environment), organic consumption (focused on promoting natural environment processes), or pro-environmental consumption (focused on maximizing positive impacts on the environment) demonstrates reproducibility. *Theoretical replicability* shows that a theory is replicable by supporting existing knowledge in *different* contexts. For instance, applying the theory of planned behavior in its original form to consumption or purchase scenarios that are fairly different, such as environmentally-friendly consumption (environment-focused) versus socially-responsible consumption (social-focused) and individual buying (individual-focused) versus group buying (group-focused), shows replicability. While these two benefits of generalizability help to validate and extend the applicability of theories across diverse contexts, they essentially involve reproducing or replicating theories in their original form and thus rank lowest in theoretical novelty. This underscores the importance of seeking innovative opportunities to achieve higher levels of theoretical novelty.

Theoretical adaptation involves taking an existing theory and fitting it to a new context without making significant changes to its core components. Theoretical adaptation builds on theoretical generalizability and thus shares the same benefits, with the addition of *theoretical*

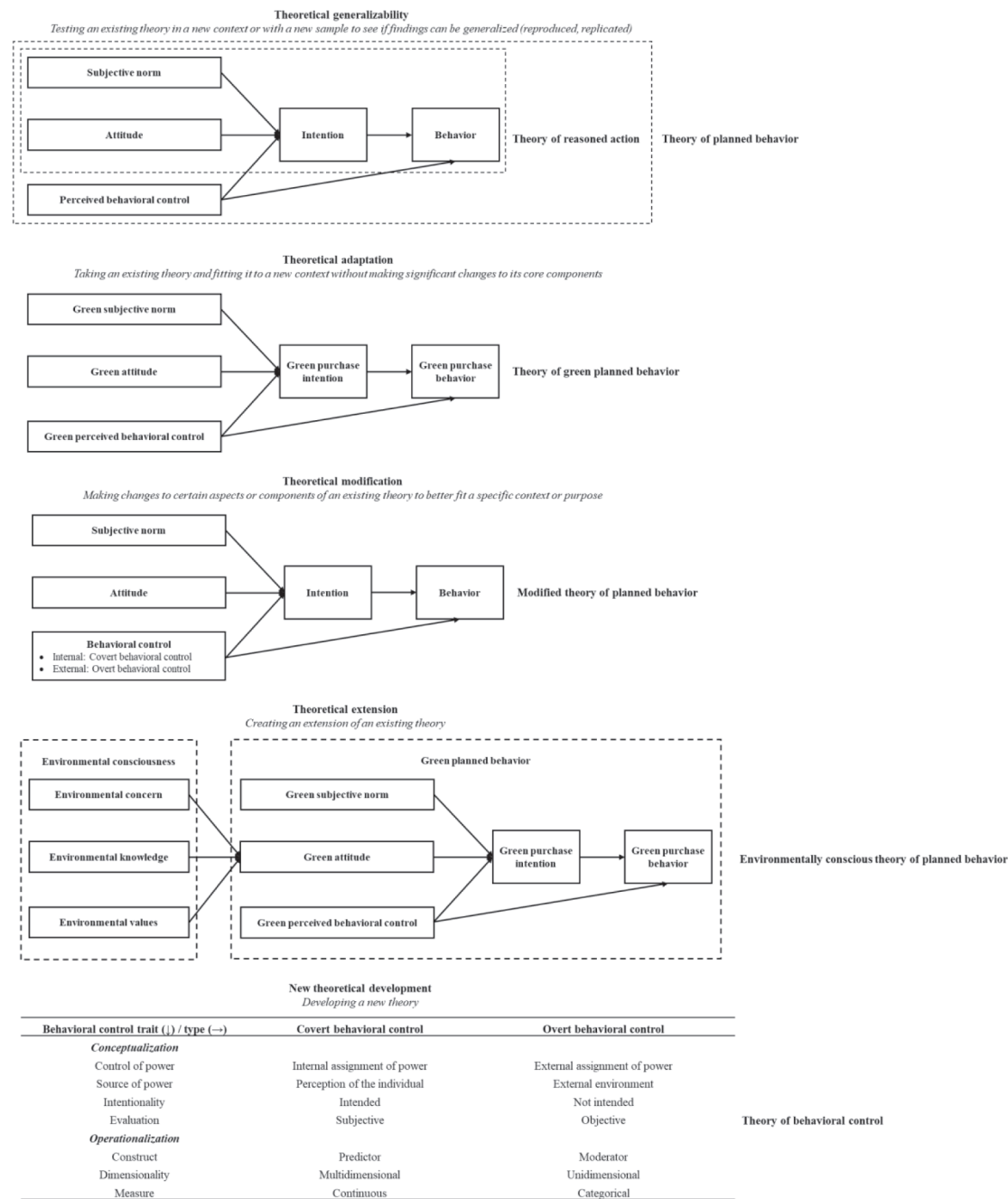
contextualization, which enables the theory to relate more relevantly to the context in which it is applied. For example, the core components of the theory of planned behavior—i.e., attitude, subjective norm, perceived behavioral control, intention, and behavior—can be adapted to the context of green purchases by “greening” the components—i.e., green attitude, green subjective norm, green perceived behavioral control, green purchase intention, and green purchase behavior—thus transforming the theory of planned behavior into the theory of green planned behavior. This adaptation not only contextualizes the theory but also enhances its relevance and practical applicability to the specific context of environmental behavior. While contextualization is beneficial, the degree of change from a theoretical perspective remains minimal, rendering the theoretical novelty of theoretical adaptation marginally better than theoretical generalizability. This further reaffirms the importance of seeking innovative opportunities to achieve higher levels of theoretical novelty.

Theoretical modification involves making changes to certain aspects or components of an existing theory to better fit a specific context or purpose. Theoretical modification shares the benefits of theoretical adaptation (with contextualization) and/or theoretical generalizability (without contextualization), with the added advantage of increasing *theoretical depth*, which enables the theory to provide finer-grained or more granular insights. For instance, perceived behavioral control, a core component of the theory of planned behavior, can be modified into a multidimensional construct by accounting for internal (covert—e.g., perceived capacity, difficulty, and self-efficacy) and external (overt—e.g., product availability, accessibility, and affordability) behavioral controls. This modification deepens theoretical understanding and enriches practical implications, such as adjusting the marketing mix to enhance product availability, accessibility, and affordability, or providing support to help consumers overcome self-challenges. Unlike the limited innovation in theoretical adaptability and theoretical generalizability, the innovation in theoretical modification that enhances theoretical depth can be reasonably considered as having an adequate level of theoretical novelty, provided that the modification is truly new. Otherwise, it falls under theoretical generalizability, and if contextualized, theoretical adaptation.

Theoretical extension involves creating an extension of an existing theory. Theoretical extension can share the benefits of theoretical generalizability, theoretical adaptation, and/or theoretical modification if the extended theory reflects any of their conditions. Noteworthy, theoretical extension has the distinct advantage of increasing *theoretical breadth*, which enables the theory to provide richer, wider insights than theoretical generalizability, theoretical adaptation, and theoretical modification. To illustrate, Laheri et al. (2024) introduced environmental consciousness as a multi-dimensional addition to the theory of planned behavior, which has also been adapted through the “greening” of the original components, yielding the environmentally conscious theory of planned behavior. The founders of this theory argued that

¹³ These are meant to be broadly applicable and to show clear distinction in the levels of novelty, and thus, they collectively offer an alternative (interdependent) perspective of theoretical contributions to existing (independent) ones (e.g., MacInnis's (2011) envisioning, explicating, relating, and debating or Jaakkola's (2020) theory synthesis, theory adaptation, typology, and model).

Panel D. Typology of theoretical contributions



Notes: The theory of reasoned action is developed by Fishbein and Ajzen (1975), the theory of planned behavior by Ajzen (1991), the theory of behavioral control by Lim and Weissmann (2023), and the environmentally conscious theory of planned behavior by Laheri et al. (2024). The figures presented here were deliberately crafted to offer a simple and straightforward representation of theoretical contributions. Although this representation may initially appear positivistic or post-positivistic because it aligns closely with empirical traditions that emphasize quantitative methods and seek clear, testable causal or correlational relationships, it should not be interpreted as excluding or restricting other paradigmatic and methodological traditions. Indeed, this typology remains highly relevant to constructivist and interpretivist approaches that are typically associated with conceptual, qualitative, and review studies. Arguably, higher degrees of theoretical novelty, particularly those pertaining to theoretical extension and new theoretical development, may be even more naturally suited to conceptual and qualitative research traditions as well as systematic literature reviews that not only describe but also critically synthesize and generate insights in ways that may not be achievable within the confines of a single empirical study. Such methodological approaches often yield richer theoretical explanations encompassing broader and deeper insights, as they commonly adopt a more holistic and systemic perspective to phenomena. In this regard, conceptual, qualitative, and review studies, which approach phenomena holistically and systemically, are especially well-positioned to unpack and illuminate theoretical complexities. Noteworthy, these studies frequently explore complexities that may not be readily measurable or testable within the confines of a single quantitative study. Consequently, while the typology illustrated here may appear visually simplistic and may imply a linear progression of theory building, it does not diminish the applicability or significance of alternative research paradigms and methodologies. Rather, conceptual, qualitative, and review methods inherently facilitate explorations of greater theoretical breadth and depth, thereby making substantive contributions not only to theoretical adaptation, modification, and extension, but especially to the development of novel (new) theoretical frameworks. Scholars are thus encouraged to appreciate this figure as inclusive of diverse paradigmatic and methodological traditions, recognizing that substantial and meaningful theoretical contributions can, and often do, emerge across the spectrum of positivistic, post-positivistic, constructivist, interpretivist, and pragmatist paradigms, as well as conceptual, qualitative, quantitative, and review methodological traditions.

Fig. 4. (continued).

Panel E. Granularity of theoretical relationships

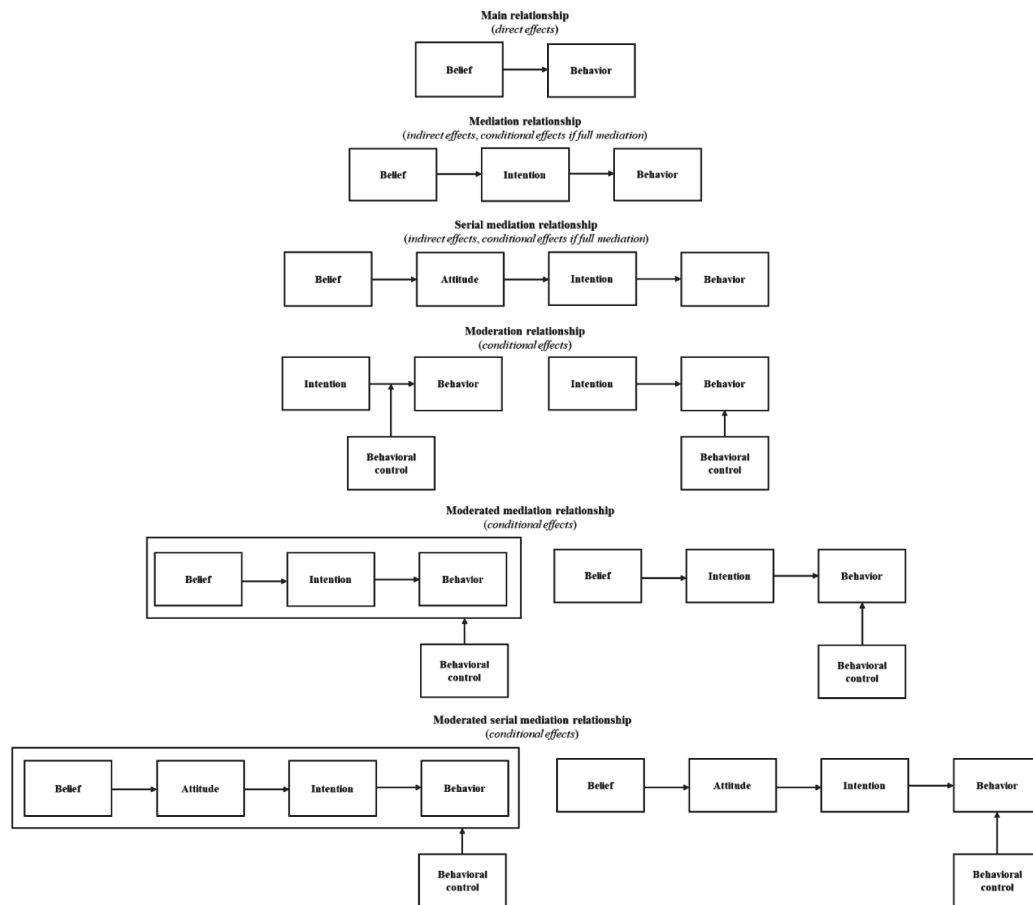


Fig. 4. (continued).

environmental consciousness has been traditionally examined in its unidimensional form, which overlooks the granularities of this consumer behavior, whereas consciousness is inherently multi-dimensional, accounting for both affective and cognitive states. Based on this premise, they introduced and validated environmental concern, environmental knowledge, and environmental values as affective, cognitive, and affective-cognitive reflections of environmental consciousness. This provided rigor through a series of analyses testing for main, mediation, and serial mediation relationships. Besides adding another well-theorized concept, whether unidimensional like the theory of planned behavior (Ajzen, 1991) or multidimensional like the environmentally conscious theory of planned behavior (Laheri et al., 2024), another possible form of theoretical extension is *theoretical synthesis*, which involves integrating multiple theories to comprehend, explain, and predict a phenomenon, as seen in the case of UTAUT (Venkatesh et al., 2003). However, integrating multiple theories on its own, without ensuring that their fit is well-theorized, is unlikely to be convincing and well understood. Hence, scholars need to explain the theoretical logic for combining multiple theories, showing why the phenomenon under study calls for their integration and how their synthesis provides a more complete understanding of that phenomenon. More importantly, like theoretical modification, theoretical extension can be reasonably considered as having an adequate level of theoretical novelty, provided that the extension is truly new.

New theoretical development involves developing a new theory. While this may happen from scratch, as in the case of grounded theory, it might also occur as a result of inadequacies in existing theories. The theory of behavioral control (Lim & Weissmann, 2023) serves as a suitable exemplar of a new theory emerging from the theory of planned behavior

(Ajzen, 1991). The founders of the theory of behavioral control contended that the original conceptualization of behavioral control in its perceived form within the theory of planned behavior limits the explanation of the intention–behavior gap. They reasoned that this gap may also be caused by external factors beyond the individual's control. For example, the availability, accessibility, and affordability of a green product can influence whether the intention to purchase a green product will materialize into an actual purchase of that green product. Through this reasoning, they introduced behavioral control as multidimensional, moving beyond its unidimensional past. This new theory provides a basis for future research to explore and examine the various covert and overt controls that may close or widen the intention–behavior gap. Given that new theoretical development is inherently novel, this form of theory development can be regarded not just as an adequate but also the highest level of theoretical novelty. Nonetheless, a granular distinction could still be made in deciding whether new theoretical development is incremental or revelatory (Corley & Gioia, 2011). While theoretical extension and theoretical modification can be reasonably considered as adequately incremental, unlike theoretical generalizability and theoretical adaptation, which are not, new theoretical development, at least in a discipline (e.g., marketing, management), can be reasonably considered as adequately revelatory when they are established as a grand theory (i.e., more abstract theories providing broader explanations that can be applied across contexts; e.g., Ajzen's (1991) theory of planned behavior, Lim and Weissmann's (2023) theory of behavioral control). Otherwise, it can be considered adequately incremental—albeit at a higher level compared to theoretical extension and theoretical modification—when they are not established as a grand theory (i.e., less abstract theories providing narrower explanations that

can only be applied in specific contexts; e.g., Keller's (1993) customer-based brand equity (CBBE) model for branding and Parasuraman et al.'s (1985) service quality (SERVQUAL) model for services).

The strength of theory development is crucial and can be established through theoretical support, theoretical legitimacy, and theoretical interestingness.

Theoretical support involves using logical and evidence-based arguments to underpin theoretical assumptions. This support is typically provided when putting forth propositions or hypotheses in the literature review or when explaining observations in the discussion.

Theoretical legitimacy, on the other hand, is established by empirically validating theoretical assumptions, thereby legitimizing theoretical contributions. While finding and lending theoretical support is more straightforward, such as citing or referencing past studies to support theoretical assumptions, establishing theoretical legitimacy is more complex. To establish theoretical legitimacy, scholars should demonstrate theoretical soundness and theoretical granularity. *Theoretical soundness* conveys the rigor and robustness of the theory, which can be demonstrated through rigorous assessments (e.g., manipulation checks for experimental studies, reliability and validity for quantitative studies, trustworthiness for qualitative and review studies) and robustness testing (e.g., using multiple measures, samples, and studies). *Theoretical granularity* involves explaining both abstraction (what, where, when, who) and assumption (how, why). For main relationships between independent and dependent variables, scholars explain "what" predictors do and do not (significantly) explain outcomes (Fig. 4 Panel E). For mediation and serial mediation relationships, scholars explain "why" the impact of an independent variable on a dependent variable can be facilitated through a mediator (partial mediation) or "how" it can be activated through a mediator (full mediation). For moderation, moderated mediation, and moderated serial mediation relationships, scholars explain "how" main, mediation, and serial mediation relationships can be influenced by a moderator (extent of effect across scenarios) or "when" these relationships are present due to a moderator (significance versus insignificance across scenarios).

Theoretical interestingness is a trait that explains why a theory is insightful (MacInnis, 2011), which may occur through *counterintuitive* (i.e., something unusual but sensible—e.g., over-endorsement does not lower purchase intentions directly but indirectly by undermining endorser credibility, though strong product interest can mitigate this effect; Cheah et al., 2024), *paradoxical* (i.e., co-existence of opposing ends—e.g., a service recovery paradox that explains how service failure transforms into brand loyalty; Lim et al., 2025), and *noteworthy* (i.e., broader (scope of impact—e.g., engagement does not only benefit brands but also consumers) or deeper (complexity of impact—e.g., engagement by contributing or consuming enhances wellbeing depending on whether the context is utilitarian or hedonic) than existing assumptions; Moriuchi et al., 2025) encounters in theory development. Advancing Davis (1971), the inclusion of paradoxicality further enriches theoretical interestingness by capturing the persistent tension between dual forces or outcomes, which differs from counterintuitivity that disrupts expectations but typically resolves into a singular logic. More importantly, the inclusion of noteworthiness as a dimension of theoretical interestingness addresses extant critiques by recalibrating the supposed dangers (e.g., discouraging replications, encouraging post-hoc hypothesis development) of an overemphasis on counterintuitiveness (Pillutla & Thau, 2013; Tihanyi, 2020; Tsang, 2022), and potentially, paradoxes, underscoring that what makes a theory interesting is not necessarily its surprise value but also its capacity to broaden or deepen prevailing assumptions. Regardless of its form, theoretical interestingness should remain aligned with truth—whether that truth manifests as counterintuitive, paradoxical, or simply noteworthy.

Therefore, a strong theory is one that is not only well problematized (practical and theoretical gaps) and novel (modified, extended, newly developed) but also with interestingness (counterintuitivity, paradoxicality, noteworthiness) that is well supported (extrapolated logic and

support from past studies) and legitimately sound (rigorous, robust) with granularity (what, where, when, who, why, how).

6. What are theoretical implications and how to establish them?

Theoretical implications exemplify the "so what" of theoretical contributions, illustrating how theories can perform two major tasks: influencing existing theoretical knowledge and guiding subsequent studies in theory development. To begin, scholars can provide stakeholders with a *recap* of the study's key theoretical aspects:

- (1) the type of theory the study sought to establish (e.g., concept theory, relationship theory, typology theory, framework (or model) theory, or integrated (or hybrid) theory),
- (2) The elements the theory explains and predicts (i.e., scope and parameters such as what, where, when, who, why, and how), and
- (3) The type of theoretical contribution (e.g., theoretical generalizability, theoretical adaptation, theoretical modification, theoretical extension, or new theoretical development), the level of theoretical novelty (e.g., adequately incremental or revelatory), and the type of theoretical interestingness (e.g., counter-intuitivity, paradoxicality, or noteworthiness) that the study endeavored to deliver.

Following this recap, scholars should engage in *retrospection* to establish the initial set of theoretical implications. This involves revisiting the theoretical gaps identified at the outset—including why these gaps were a problem—and explaining how the study's theoretical contributions address these gaps. Scholars should demonstrate how their contributions affirm, extend, refine, challenge, or even refute existing theoretical understanding, thereby deepening the depth and expanding the breadth of our theoretical comprehension, explanation, and prediction of complex phenomena.

Next, scholars should engage in *reimagination* to establish the next set of theoretical implications. This involves outlining how future research can build upon and enhance the novelty and scope of the current theoretical contributions. Scholars should identify new areas of inquiry, propose modifications or extensions to existing theories, and suggest new ways in which the theory can be applied to different contexts or integrated with other theories. This should be accompanied by signposts of theoretical problematization and interestingness—or in other words, the "why" of these suggestions—so that these suggestions are compelling enough to warrant investment of talent (knowledge, skills), time (weekdays, weekends), treasure (funds), and ties (networks). In doing so, they provide a roadmap for future research, ensuring the return on value (ROV) of ongoing development and evolution of theoretical knowledge (Fig. 5).

7. Conclusion

This guide has offered a comprehensive framework for understanding and developing theories in scholarly research, addressing the need for clear, coherent, and constructive guidelines. Grounded in the author's *expertise*, *experience*, and *exposure* (3Es), the guide addresses the fragmentation of theory development guidelines by delineating a sequential approach to spotting and problematizing *theoretical gaps*, establishing strong *theoretical foundations*, positioning *theoretical contributions*, and articulating *theoretical implications*—a collective framework with details and perspectives that, to the best knowledge of the author, has not been formally established, and thus, this framework can be considered adequately *novel* and *seminal* in nature (Fig. 6).¹⁴

The exploration of *theoretical gaps* underscores the necessity,

¹⁴ A countercheck mapping can be done using the *AMJ Management Research Canvas* (Dorobantu et al., 2024).

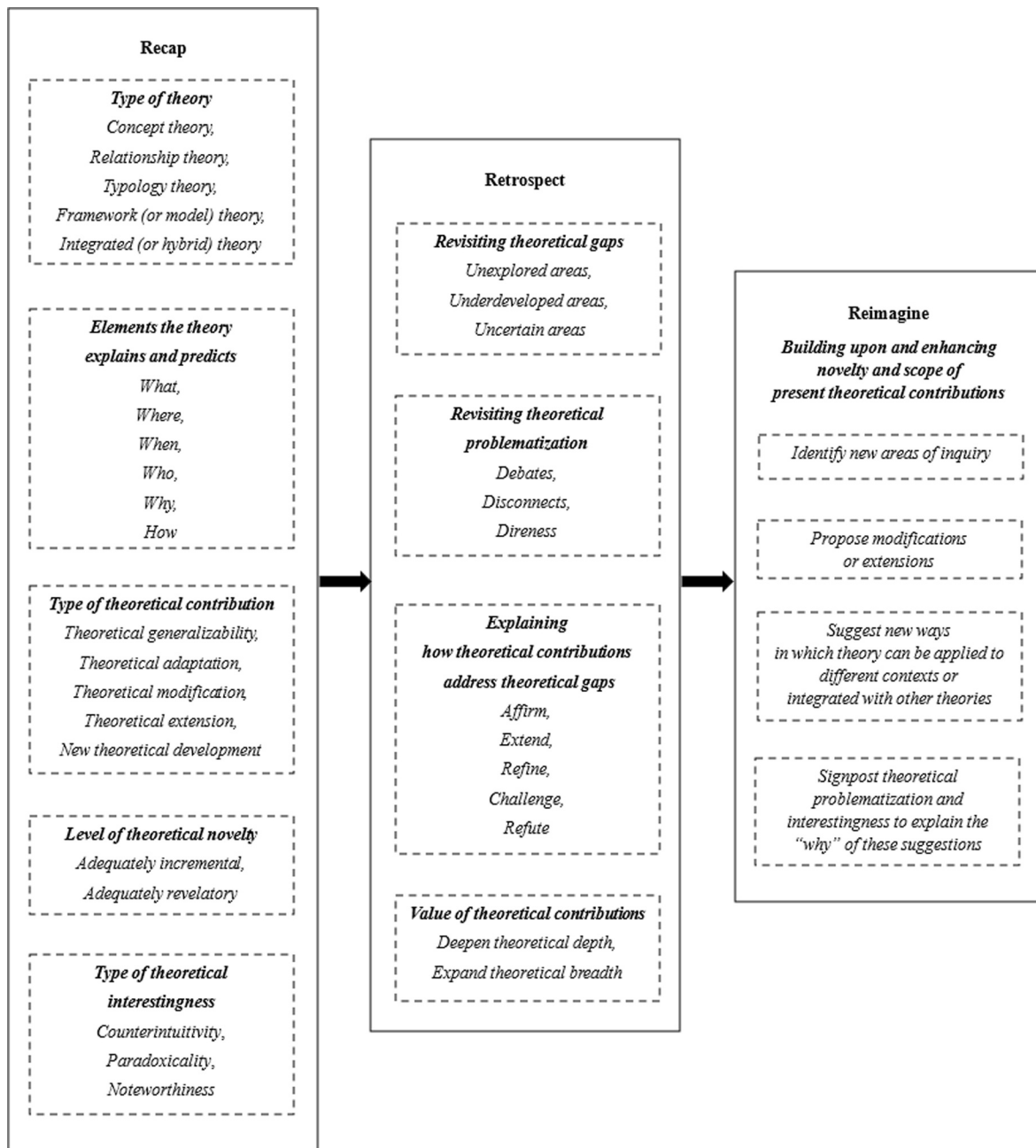


Fig. 5. Establishing theoretical implications: Recap, retrospect, and reimagine (3Rs).

importance, relevance, and urgency of spotting and problematizing unexplored, underdeveloped, and uncertain areas within literature. Recognizing current theories' strengths and shortcomings and embracing necessary changes—whether through adaptation, modification, extension, or new development—allows scholars to address these gaps, enhancing the value of theories. Ensuring theories remain applicable and adaptable across diverse contexts is thus crucial for advancing the field.

The emphasis on *theoretical novelty* highlights the necessity of innovation in theory development. The typology of *theoretical contributions*—ranging from theoretical generalizability and adaptation to modification, extension, and new development—and *theoretical interestingness*—including counterintuitivity, paradoxicality, and noteworthiness—provides an *original* structured approach for scholars to pursue novel and impactful theoretical advancements. Coupled with a focus on *theoretical support* and *theoretical legitimacy*, this typology

ensures theories are both well-grounded and empirically validated.

The guide also elucidates the critical role of *theoretical implications*, which demonstrates the value of theoretical contributions by influencing existing knowledge and guiding future research. Establishing robust theoretical implications through a structured process of *recapping* the study's theoretical aspects, *retrospecting* to address theoretical gaps, and *reimagining* future research directions ensures the continuous evolution of theoretical knowledge. The distinction and interrelation between theoretical contribution and theoretical implication herein also points to another *unique* contribution of this guide to the extant discourse on theory and theory development. More importantly, the process described here should not be viewed as strictly linear or as a final endpoint. Instead, this process reflects the realistic, *iterative* nature of how theories actually develop. That is to say, in practice, theoretical implications often lead directly to the identification of new theoretical gaps (e.g., uncovering opportunities for further theoretical extensions),

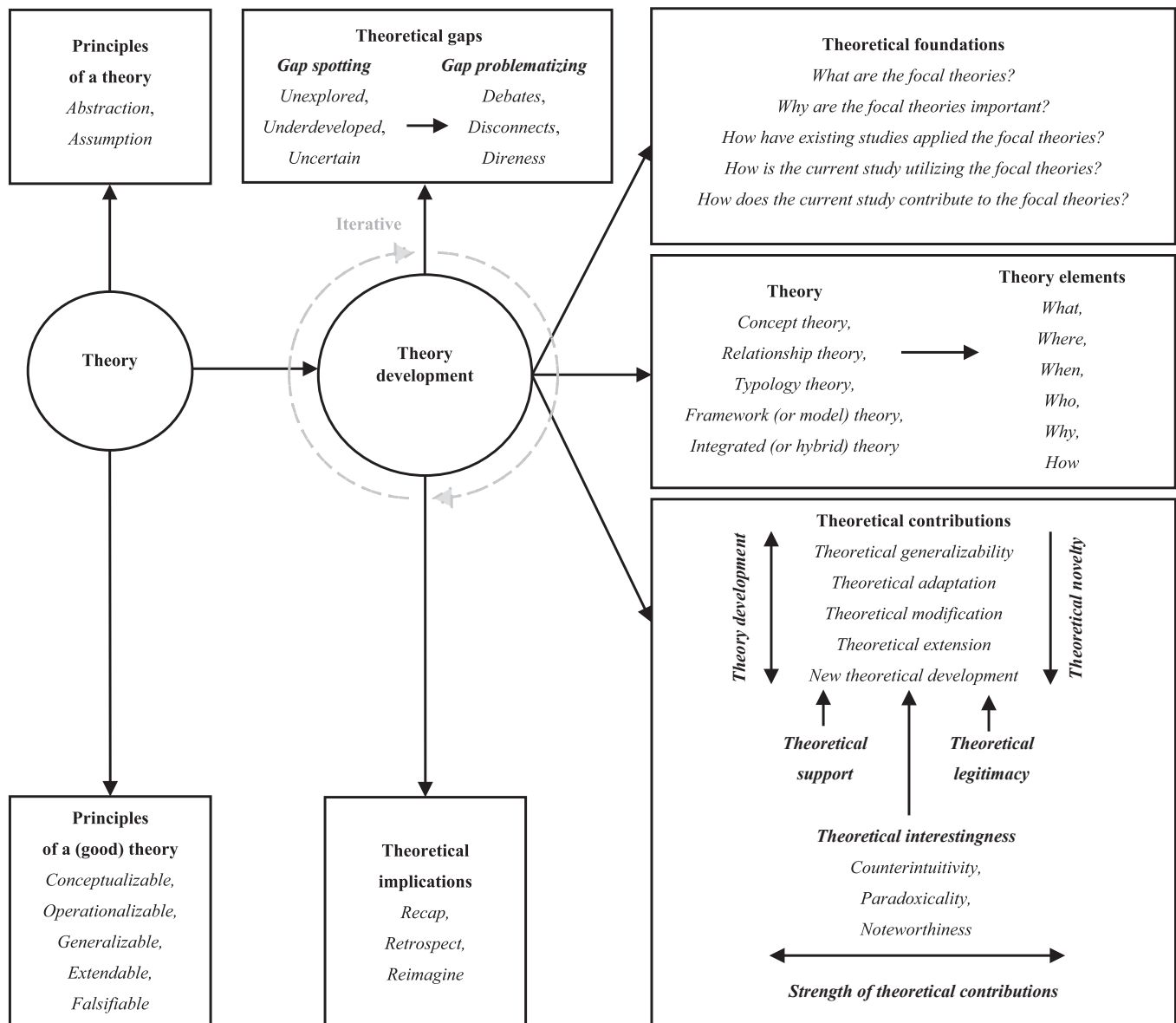


Fig. 6. Framework of theory and theory development.

wherein such gaps, in turn, prompt scholars to revisit and strengthen theoretical foundations (e.g., incorporating insights from recent theoretical contributions), pursue additional theoretical contributions (e.g., developing new theoretical endeavors), and subsequently establish fresh theoretical implications (e.g., insights resulting from these newly developed theories) that not only advance discourse but also endure as generative insights for subsequent cycles of theory development. This cyclical view, in turn, underscores the continuous feedback loops, iterative revisions, and ongoing refinements that characterize the nature of theory development while also reminding that the worth of these iterations lies in producing contributions that endure beyond their immediate novelty and remain valuable for future theorizing.

When looking back at the issues motivating this endeavor, it is clear that this guide contributes significantly by addressing fragmentation, clarifying interestingness, and offering practical guidance on achieving theoretical novelty—areas previously lacking integrated treatment in existing literature. More specifically, fragmentation is systematically addressed by presenting an integrated and sequential framework, as illustrated in Fig. 6, thereby transforming isolated theoretical insights into a coherent roadmap for theory development. This guide also moves

beyond existing conceptualizations of interestingness by structuring theoretical interestingness into clearly defined pathways (i.e., counterintuitivity, paradoxicality, and noteworthiness), thus providing scholars precise avenues to pursue theoretically impactful scholarship. Moreover, by explicitly delineating the conditions and thresholds for achieving theoretical novelty—from generalizability and adaptation through to modification, extension, and new development—this guide empowers scholars to strategically align their theoretical ambitions with publication expectations. Therefore, when taken collectively, these contributions not only enhance theoretical clarity but also elevate the practicality and impact of theory-building efforts, thereby effectively responding to both existing and emerging debates in the discourse of theory and theory development.

Notwithstanding these insights, this guide does not extensively discuss the practical challenges scholars may encounter when applying these guidelines for theory development—and intentionally so, because the primary goal here was to directly address existing gaps in theoretical clarity rather than anticipate every potential difficulty that might arise in practice. Such practical challenges, if and when they arise, should become points for future scholarly debate, empirical validation, and

refinement of these guidelines. For example, theoretical assumptions across different research streams may vary significantly, leading to tensions and uncertainties—issues explicitly positioned here as motivators for further exploration (i.e., addressing areas of uncertainty). Similarly, practical issues in operationalization, including scale adaptation, modification, or entirely new scale development, were deliberately excluded from detailed discussion, as these methodological considerations are comprehensively treated in specialized methodological guides. In addition, while critique and calls for theoretical innovation are acknowledged as critical drivers of theoretical advancement, managing resistance to theoretical change falls outside the immediate focus of this article. Moreover, though the illustrative examples primarily emphasize behavioral theories, such as the theory of planned behavior and the theory of behavioral control, these theories were strategically selected for their wide relevance across multiple fields, including consumer and organizational behavior. Nonetheless, this guide has also presented a wide range of theories, as seen in the discussion of concept theory (e.g., customer brand engagement from marketing, health equity from healthcare), relationship theory (e.g., Herzberg's dual-factor theory from organizational psychology, catering theory of dividends from finance), typology theory (e.g., values and lifestyles framework, Roger's diffusion of innovations theory and its application in agriculture, fashion, and finance), framework (or model) theory (e.g., theory of planned behavior from psychology and its application in ethics, education, management, marketing, and tourism; health belief model from healthcare), and integrated (or hybrid) theory (e.g., integrated model of sustainable consumption from marketing, unified theory of technology acceptance and use of technology and its application in consumer and organizational contexts). Hence, this guide, arguably, remains widely applicable, as it provides scholars across disciplines with a foundation from which they can extrapolate and apply these principles to their own theoretical development efforts, though future scholarly discussions around theory and theory development would benefit from commenting, if not validating, the clarity and practical usefulness of the guidelines presented here.

To this end, this guide equips scholars with the insights and tools needed to develop, refine, and advance theories that are not only scientifically rigorous but also practically relevant. Following these guidelines, scholars can contribute meaningfully to the advancement of knowledge across disciplines, including the development of research streams, thus ensuring their research has a lasting impact on both theory and practice.

Source of funding

None.

Declaration of competing interest

The author has served as an Associate Editor of the *Journal of Business Research* and was excluded from editorial decision-making related to the acceptance of this article for publication in the journal.

Acknowledgement

The author conveys his sincere appreciation to Dipayan Biswas and Mirella Kleijnen for early feedback, Bert Weijters for ongoing feedback, as well as Linda Desiree Hollebeek, Pervaiz Khalid Ahmed, Stephen Thomas Homer, and Viswanath Venkatesh for thoughtful conversations and seminars that have shaped his views on theory and theory development. The author is also grateful to the anonymous reviewers whose probing questions challenged him to think more deeply, both critically and with simplicity, yet who entrusted him with the intellectual freedom to craft his own voice in response. As the author believes, “*Theories grow not by shielding them from scrutiny, but by inviting it, and meeting it with reasoned courage.*”

Data availability

No data was collected or used for this theory-focused article.

References

- Adekoya, C. O. (2023). Library funding and sustainable development of higher education. *International Information & Library Review*, 55(4), 317–328. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10572317.2023.2167053>
- Ågerfalk, P. J. (2014). Insufficient theoretical contribution: A conclusive rationale for rejection? *European Journal of Information Systems*, 23(6), 593–599. <https://doi.org/10.1057/ejis.2014.35>
- Aguinis, H., & Cronin, M. A. (2025). It's the theory, stupid. *Organizational Psychology Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/20413866221080629>
- Ajzen, I. (1991). The theory of planned behavior. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 50(2), 179–211. [https://doi.org/10.1016/0749-5978\(91\)90020-T](https://doi.org/10.1016/0749-5978(91)90020-T)
- Ajzen, I. (2011). Reflections on Morgan and Bachrach's critique. *Vienna Yearbook of Population Research*, 9, 63–69. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/41342804>
- Ajzen, I. (2020). The theory of planned behavior: Frequently asked questions. *Human Behavior and Emerging Technologies*, 2(4), 314–324. <https://doi.org/10.1002/hbe2.195>
- Alvargonzález, D. (2011). Multidisciplinarity, interdisciplinarity, transdisciplinarity, and the sciences. *International Studies in the Philosophy of Science*, 25(4), 387–403. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02698595.2011.623366>
- Alvesson, M., & Sandberg, J. (2020). The problematizing review: A counterpoint to Elsbach and Van Knippenberg's argument for integrative reviews. *Journal of Management Studies*, 57(6), 1290–1304. <https://doi.org/10.1111/joms.12582>
- Armitage, C. J., & Conner, M. (2001). Efficacy of the theory of planned behaviour: A meta-analytic review. *British Journal of Social Psychology*, 40(4), 471–499. <https://doi.org/10.1348/014466601164939>
- Astley, W. G., & Van de Ven, A. H. (1983). Central perspectives and debates in organization theory. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 28(2), 245–273. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2392620>
- Ayisi, D. N., Kozáři, J., & Krisztina, T. (2022). Do smallholder farmers belong to the same adopter category? An assessment of smallholder farmers innovation adopter categories in Ghana. *Heliyon*, 8(8), Article e10421. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2022.e10421>
- Bacharach, S. B. (1989). Organizational theories: Some criteria for evaluation. *Academy of Management Review*, 14(4), 496–515. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.1989.4308374>
- Bagozzi, R. P. (1984). A prospectus for theory construction in marketing. *Journal of Marketing*, 48(1), 11–29. <https://doi.org/10.1177/002224298404800102>
- Baker, M., & Wurgler, J. (2004). A catering theory of dividends. *The Journal of Finance*, 59(3), 1125–1165. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-6261.2004.00658.x>
- Barney, J. (2018). Positioning a theory paper for publication. *Academy of Management Review*, 43(3), 345–348. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2018.0112>
- Bartunek, J. M., & Lei, C. Y. (2025). Creating theory that is generative for scholarship and practice. *Organizational Psychology Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/20413866231207001>
- Behn, O., Wichmann, J., Leyer, M., & Schilling, A. (2025). Spillover effects in environmental behaviors: A scoping review about its antecedents, behaviors, and consequences. *Current Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12144-025-07431-9>
- Bhardwaj, A., Sergeeva, A., Mahoney, J., & Nickerson, J. (2025). Theorizing as problem solving: A pragmatist perspective on the logic of pursuit. *Strategy Science*. <https://doi.org/10.1287/stsc.2023.0075>
- Black, E. L., Burton, F. G., & Cieslewicz, J. K. (2022). Improving ethics: Extending the theory of planned behavior to include moral disengagement. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 181(4), 945–978. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-021-04896-z>
- Bull, S., Cooper, A., Laidlaw, A., Milne, L., & Parr, S. (2025). ‘You certainly don't get promoted for just teaching’: Experiences of education-focused academics in research-intensive universities. *Studies in Higher Education*, 50(2), 239–255. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03075079.2024.2333946>
- Calder, B. J., He, S., & Sternthal, B. (2023). Using theoretical frameworks in behavioral research. *Journal of Business Research*, 161, Article 113758. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2023.113758>
- Campbell, J. T., & Aguilera, R. V. (2022). Why I rejected your paper: Common pitfalls in writing theory papers and how to avoid them. *Academy of Management Review*, 47(4), 521–527. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2022.0331>
- Carton, A. M. (2025). The six dimensions of strong theory. *Organization Science*. <https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.2024.19018>
- Cheah, C. W., Koay, K. Y., & Lim, W. M. (2024). Social media influencer over-endorsement: Implications from a moderated-mediation analysis. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, 79, Article 103831. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2024.103831>
- Compagnucci, L., & Spigarelli, F. (2020). The Third Mission of the university: A systematic literature review on potentials and constraints. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 161, Article 120284. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.techfore.2020.120284>
- Corley, K. G., & Gioia, D. A. (2011). Building theory about theory building: What constitutes a theoretical contribution? *Academy of Management Review*, 36(1), 12–32. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2009.0486>
- Corley, K. G., & Schinoff, B. S. (2017). Who, me? An inductive study of novice experts in the context of how editors come to understand theoretical contribution. *Academy of Management Perspectives*, 31(1), 4–27. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amp.2015.0131>

- Cornelissen, J. P. (2017). Preserving theoretical divergence in management research: Why the explanatory potential of qualitative research should be harnessed rather than suppressed. *Journal of Management Studies*, 54(3), 368–383. <https://doi.org/10.1111/joms.12210>
- Cornelissen, J. P., & Durand, R. (2014). Moving forward: Developing theoretical contributions in management studies. *Journal of Management Studies*, 51(6), 995–1022. <https://doi.org/10.1111/joms.12078>
- Davis, M. S. (1971). That's interesting! Towards a phenomenology of sociology and a sociology of phenomenology. *Philosophy of the Social Sciences*, 1(2), 309–344. <https://doi.org/10.1177/004839317100100211>
- de Zeeuw, A. (2024). Climate change, tipping points, and economics. *Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Economics*, 109, Article 102185. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socec.2024.102185>
- Dietvorst, B. J., Simmons, J. P., & Massey, C. (2015). Algorithm aversion: People erroneously avoid algorithms after seeing them err. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, 144(1), 114–126. <https://doi.org/10.1037/xge0000033>
- DiMaggio, P. J. (1995). Comments on "what theory is not". *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 40, 391–397. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2393790>
- Dorobantu, S., Gruber, M., Ravasi, D., & Wellman, N. (2024). The AMJ management research canvas: A tool for conducting and reporting empirical research. *Academy of Management Journal*, 67(5), 1163–1174. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2024.4005>
- Dubin, R. (1978). *Theory development*. New York: Free Press.
- Dwivedi, Y. K., Hughes, L., Cheung, C. M., Conboy, K., Duan, Y., Dubey, R., & Viglia, G. (2022). How to develop a quality research article and avoid a journal desk rejection. *International Journal of Information Management*, 62, Article 102426. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2021.102426>
- Erul, E., Woosnam, K. M., & McIntosh, W. A. (2020). Considering emotional solidarity and the theory of planned behavior in explaining behavioral intentions to support tourism development. *Journal of Sustainable Tourism*, 28(8), 1158–1173. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09669582.2020.1726935>
- Fishbein, M., & Ajzen, I. (1975). *Belief, attitude, intention and behavior*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Fishbein, M., & Ajzen, I. (2010). In *Predicting and changing behavior: The reasoned action approach*. New York: Psychology Press (Taylor & Francis). <https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203838020>
- George, G., Howard-Grenville, J., Joshi, A., & Tihanyi, L. (2016). Understanding and tackling societal grand challenges through management research. *Academy of Management Journal*, 59(6), 1880–1895. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2016.4007>
- Golder, P. N., Dekimpe, M. G., An, J. T., Van Heerde, H. J., Kim, D. S., & Alba, J. W. (2023). Learning from data: An empirics-first approach to relevant knowledge generation. *Journal of Marketing*, 87(3), 319–336. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00222429221129200>
- Greenwood, D. J., & Levin, M. (1998). *Introduction to action research: Social research for social change*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Grolleau, G., & Meunier, L. (2024). Legitimacy through research, not rankings: A provocation and proposal for business schools. *Academy of Management Learning & Education*, 23(2), 325–342. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amle.2022.0222>
- Gümüşay, A. A., & Reinecke, J. (2024). Imagining desirable futures: A call for prospective theorizing with speculative rigour. *Organization Theory*, 5(1), 1–23. <https://doi.org/10.1177/26317877241235939>
- Harley, J. (2016). High prices to access scholarly research could drive developing country researchers to use pirate sites like SciHub. *London School of Economics and Political Science*.
- Herzberg, F., Mausner, B., & Snyderman, B. B. (1959). *The motivation to work*. New York: John Wiley & Sons.
- Higgins, J. P., & Thompson, S. G. (2002). Quantifying heterogeneity in a meta-analysis. *Statistics in Medicine*, 21(11), 1539–1558. <https://doi.org/10.1002/sim.1186>
- Hoang, S., Ta, B., Khong, H., & Dang, T. T. D. (2023). Australia has way more PhD graduates than academic jobs. Here's how to rethink doctoral degrees. *The Conversation*. <https://theconversation.com/australia-has-way-more-phd-graduates-than-academic-jobs-heres-how-to-rethink-doctoral-degrees-203057>
- Ho, V. C., Berman, A. H., Andrade, J., Kavanagh, D. J., Branche, S. L., May, J., & Blumstein, D. T. (2024). Assessing immediate emotions in the theory of planned behavior can substantially contribute to increases in pro-environmental behavior. *Frontiers in Climate*, 6, Article 1344899. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fclim.2024.1344899>
- Hollebeek, L. (2011). Exploring customer brand engagement: Definition and themes. *Journal of Strategic Marketing*, 19(7), 555–573. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0965254X.2011.599493>
- Hollebeek, L. D., Srivastava, R. K., Clark, M. K., Urbonavicius, S., & Lim, W. M. (2024). Crafting conceptual proposition-based contributions: The 7C framework. *Psychology & Marketing*, 41(10), 2396–2411. <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.22055>
- Hollebeek, L. D., Kumar, V., Srivastava, R. K., Lim, W. M., & Urbonavicius, S. (2025). Guidelines for theory selection: The IMPACT framework. *Psychology & Marketing*. <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.70009>
- Homer, S. T., & Lim, W. M. (2024). Theory development in a globalized world: Bridging "doing as the Romans do" with "understanding why the Romans do it". *Global Business and Organizational Excellence*, 43(3), 127–138. <https://doi.org/10.1002/joe.22234>
- Hrubes, D., Ajzen, I., & Daigle, J. (2001). Predicting hunting intentions and behavior: An application of the theory of planned behavior. *Leisure Sciences*, 23(3), 165–178. <https://doi.org/10.1080/014904001316896855>
- Hulland, J. (2020). Conceptual review papers: Revisiting existing research to develop and refine theory. *AMS Review*, 10(1), 27–35. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13162-020-00168-7>
- Jaakkola, E. (2020). Designing conceptual articles: Four approaches. *AMS Review*, 10(1), 18–26. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13162-020-00161-0>
- Jaccard, J., & Jacoby, J. (2020). *Theory construction and model-building skills: A practical guide for social scientists* (2nd edition). New York: The Guilford Press.
- Janz, N. K., & Becker, M. H. (1984). The health belief model: A decade later. *Health Education Quarterly*, 11(1), 1–47. <https://doi.org/10.1177/109019818401100101>
- Jonäll, K., Arvidsson, S., Bäckström, Y., & Elliot, V. (2025). The biodiversity–finance nexus: A future research agenda. *Current Opinion in Environmental Sustainability*, 72, Article 101504. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cosust.2024.101504>
- Keller, K. L. (1993). Conceptualizing, measuring, and managing customer-based brand equity. *Journal of Marketing*, 57(1), 1–22. <https://doi.org/10.1177/002224299305700101>
- Koley, M. (2024). India's 'One Nation, One Subscription' plan. *The Hindu*. <https://www.thehindu.com/sci-tech/science/indias-one-nation-one-subscription-plan-explained/article68938128.ece>
- Koskela-Huotari, K. (2024). How to craft a compelling storyline for a conceptual paper. *AMS Review*, 14, 174–181. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13162-024-00292-8>
- Kraus, S., Breier, M., Lim, W. M., Dabić, M., Kumar, S., Kanbach, D., & Ferreira, J. J. (2022). Literature reviews as independent studies: Guidelines for academic practice. *Review of Managerial Science*, 16(8), 2577–2595. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11846-022-00588-8>
- Laheri, V. K., Lim, W. M., Arya, P. K., & Kumar, S. (2024). A multidimensional lens of environmental consciousness: Towards an environmentally conscious theory of planned behavior. *Journal of Consumer Marketing*, 41(3), 281–297. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JCM-03-2023-5875>
- Lewis, C. L., Yan, A., Williams, M. Y., Apen, L. V., Crawford, C. L., Morse, L., & Beatty, D. (2023). Health equity: A concept analysis. *Nursing Outlook*, 71(5), Article 102032. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.outlook.2023.102032>
- Liang, Z., Mao, J., & Li, G. (2023). Bias against scientific novelty: A prepublication perspective. *Journal of the Association for Information Science and Technology*, 74(1), 99–114. <https://doi.org/10.1002/asi.24725>
- Lim, W. M. (2017). Inside the sustainable consumption theoretical toolbox: Critical concepts for sustainability, consumption, and marketing. *Journal of Business Research*, 78, 69–80. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2017.05.001>
- Lim, W. M. (2022). The sustainability pyramid: A hierarchical approach to greater sustainability and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals with implications for marketing theory, practice, and public policy. *Australasian Marketing Journal*, 30(2), 142–150. <https://doi.org/10.1177/18393349211069152>
- Lim, W. M. (2023). Critique and change: The "what", "why", "how", and "so what". *Global Business and Organizational Excellence*, 42(3), 5–9. <https://doi.org/10.1002/joe.22202>
- Lim, W. M., & Bowman, C. (2023). How to establish practical contributions and convey practical implications? Guidelines on locating practice gaps and making recommendations for practice. *Activities, Adaptation & Aging*, 47(3), 263–282. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01924788.2023.2232220>
- Lim, W. M., & Weissmann, M. A. (2023). Toward a theory of behavioral control. *Journal of Strategic Marketing*, 31(1), 185–211. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0965254X.2021.1890190>
- Lim, W. M., Kumar, S., & Ali, F. (2022). Advancing knowledge through literature reviews: 'What', 'why', and 'how to contribute'. *The Service Industries Journal*, 42 (7–8), 481–513. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02642069.2022.2047941>
- Lim, W. M., Saha, V., & Das, M. (2025). From service failure to brand loyalty: Evidence of service recovery paradox. *Journal of Brand Management*. <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41262-025-00380-5>
- Lönngren, J., & Van Poeck, K. (2021). Wicked problems: A mapping review of the literature. *International Journal of Sustainable Development & World Ecology*, 28(6), 481–502. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13504509.2020.1859415>
- Lorenzoni, G., & Ferriani, S. (2008). Searching for new units of analysis: Firms, dyads and networks. *European Management Review*, 5(2), 125–133. <https://doi.org/10.1057/emr.2008.8>
- Lysyakov, M., Kannan, P. K., Viswanathan, S., & Zhang, K. (2025). Retailer differentiation in social media: An investigation of firm-generated content on Twitter. *Journal of Marketing*, 89(4), 39–58. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00222429241298654>
- MacInnis, D. J. (2011). A framework for conceptual contributions in marketing. *Journal of Marketing*, 75(4), 136–154. <https://doi.org/10.1509/jmk.75.4.136>
- MacKenzie, S. B. (2003). The dangers of poor construct conceptualization. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 31(3), 323–326. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0092070303031003011>
- Madalli, D. (2025). India's bold first step to an open science future. *Nature*. <https://doi.org/10.1038/d44151-025-00028-y>
- Makadok, R., Burton, R., & Barney, J. (2018). A practical guide for making theory contributions in strategic management. *Strategic Management Journal*, 39(6), 1530–1545. <https://doi.org/10.1002/smj.2789>
- Michie, S., West, R., Campbell, R., Brown, J., & Gaining, H. (2014). *ABC of behaviour change theories*. Bream, GL: Silverback Publishing.
- Mindel, V., & Ciriello, R. F. (2025, June 24). Safeguarding academic legitimacy: Editorial conflicts of interest as a principal-agent problem in elite business journals. *SSRN*. <https://ssrn.com/abstract=5315585>
- Mori, M. (1970). The uncanny valley. *Energy*, 7(4), 33–35.
- Moriuchi, E., Hollebeek, L. D., & Lim, W. M. (2025). Consumers' smartphone addiction: Impact of engagement and app type on wellbeing. *Journal of Business Research*, 194, Article 115379. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2025.115379>
- Mukherjee, D., Lim, W. M., Kumar, S., & Donthu, N. (2022). Guidelines for advancing theory and practice through bibliometric research. *Journal of Business Research*, 148, 101–115. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2022.04.042>

- Muntinga, D. G., Moorman, M., & Smit, E. G. (2011). Introducing COBRAs: Exploring motivations for brand-related social media use. *International Journal of Advertising*, 30(1), 13–46. <https://doi.org/10.2501/IJA-30-1-013-046>
- Nicolli, F., Gilli, M., & Vona, F. (2025). Inequality and climate change: Two problems, one solution? *Energy Economics*, 145, Article 108390. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.eneco.2025.108390>
- Nietzel, M. T. (2024). Number of doctoral degrees awarded in U.S. rebounds to all-time high. *Forbes*. <https://www.forbes.com/sites/michaelnietzel/2024/02/05/number-of-doctoral-degrees-awarded-in-us-rebounds-to-all-time-high/>
- Okur, N. (2022). Consumer adoption of fast-fashion, differences of perceptions, and the role of motivations across the adoption groups. *Autex Research Journal*, 22(3), 365–372. <https://doi.org/10.2478/aut-2021-0024>
- ONOS. (2025). One Nation One Subscription. *Government of India*. <https://onos.gov.in/>
- Parasuraman, A., Zeithaml, V. A., & Berry, L. L. (1985). A conceptual model of service quality and its implications for future research. *Journal of Marketing*, 49(4), 41–50. <https://doi.org/10.1177/002224298504900403>
- Pillutla, M. M., & Thau, S. (2013). Organizational sciences' obsession with "that's interesting!" Consequences and an alternative. *Organizational Psychology Review*, 3(2), 187–194. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2041386613479963>
- Rogers, E. M. (1962). *Diffusion of innovations* (1st edition). New York: Free Press.
- Rzayev, K., Sakkas, A., & Urquhart, A. (2025). An adoption model of cryptocurrencies. *European Journal of Operational Research*, 323(1), 253–266. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ejor.2024.11.024>
- Sandberg, J., & Alvesson, M. (2011). Ways of constructing research questions: Gap-spotting or problematization? *Organization*, 18(1), 23–44. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1350508410372151>
- Sarrico, C. S. (2022). The expansion of doctoral education and the changing nature and purpose of the doctorate. *Higher Education*, 84(6), 1299–1315. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-022-00946-1>
- Shepherd, D. A., & Suddaby, R. (2017). Theory building: A review and integration. *Journal of Management*, 43(1), 59–86. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206316647102>
- Strategic Business Insights. (2024). About VALS™. <https://client.strategicbusinessinsights.com/vals/about.shtml>
- Suddaby, R. (2010). Construct clarity in theories of management and organization. *Academy of Management Review*, 35(3), 346–357. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.35.3.zok346>
- Sun, H., Wen, W., Thatcher, J. B., Chau, M., & Brown, S. A. (2025). Rebalancing novelty with rigor and relevance in information systems research. *Management Information Systems Quarterly*, 49(3), iii–xi. <https://doi.org/10.25300/MISQ/2025/493E1>
- Sutton, R. I., & Staw, B. M. (1995). What theory is not. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 40(3), 371–384. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2393788>
- Tellis, G. (2017). Interesting and impactful research: On phenomena, theory, and writing. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 45, 1–6. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11747-016-0499-0>
- Thatcher, S. M., & Fisher, G. (2022). The nuts and bolts of writing a theory paper: A practical guide to getting started. *Academy of Management Review*, 47(1), 1–8. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2021.0483>
- Tihanyi, L. (2020). From "that's interesting" to "that's important". *Academy of Management Journal*, 63(2), 329–331. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amj.2020.4002>
- To, W. M., & Yu, B. T. (2023). Rise in higher education researchers and academic publications. *Emerald Open Research*, 1(3). <https://doi.org/10.1108/EOR-03-2023-0008>
- Tsang, E. W. (2022). That's interesting! A flawed article has influenced generations of management researchers. *Journal of Management Inquiry*, 31(2), 150–164. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10564926211048708>
- Ulag, W., Kleinaltenkamp, M., Kashyap, V., & Eggert, A. (2021). Advancing marketing theory and practice: Guidelines for crafting research propositions. *AMS Review*, 11, 395–406. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13162-021-00215-x>
- United Nations. (2021). Secretary-general calls latest IPCC climate report 'code red for humanity', stressing 'irrefutable' evidence of human influence. <https://press.un.org/en/2021/sgsm20847.doc.htm>
- Valentine, D. B., & Powers, L. T. (2013). Generation Y values and lifestyle segments. *Journal of Consumer Marketing*, 30(7), 597–606. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JCM-07-2013-0650>
- Van de Ven, A. H. (1989). Nothing is quite so practical as a good theory. *Academy of Management Review*, 14(4), 486–489. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.1989.4308370>
- Van de Ven, A. H., & Poole, M. S. (1995). Explaining development and change in organizations. *Academy of Management Review*, 20(3), 510–540. <https://doi.org/10.2307/258786>
- Van Hierden, Y., Dietrich, T., & Rundle-Thiele, S. (2022). BUILD: A five-step process to develop theory-driven social marketing interventions. *Journal of Social Marketing*, 12(4), 473–494. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JSOCM-11-2021-0252>
- Varadarajan, R. (2017). Musings on interesting and impactful theory and research. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, 45(1), 10–13. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11747-016-0500-y>
- Venkatesh, V. (2025). Leveraging context: Re-thinking research processes to make "contributions to theory. *Information Systems Research*. <https://doi.org/10.1287/isre.2021.0048>
- Venkatesh, V., Morris, M. G., Davis, G. B., & Davis, F. D. (2003). User acceptance of information technology: Toward a unified view. *MIS Quarterly*, 27(3), 425–478. <https://doi.org/10.2307/30036540>
- Venkatesh, V., Thong, J. Y., & Xu, X. (2012). Consumer acceptance and use of information technology: Extending the unified theory of acceptance and use of technology. *MIS Quarterly*, 36(1), 157–178. <https://doi.org/10.2307/41410412>
- Viglia, G., Zaeafarian, G., & Ulqinaku, A. (2021). How to design good experiments in marketing: Types, examples, and methods. *Industrial Marketing Management*, 98, 193–206. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.indmarman.2021.08.007>
- Voet, M., & De Wever, B. (2020). How do teachers prioritize instructional goals? Using the theory of planned behavior to explain goal coverage. *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 89, Article 103005. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tate.2019.103005>
- Weick, K. E. (1989). Theory construction as disciplined imagination. *Academy of Management Review*, 14(4), 516–531. <https://doi.org/10.2307/258556>
- Weick, K. E. (1995). What theory is not, theorizing is. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 40(3), 385–390. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2393789>
- Wen, J. (2025). Innovation through conceptual research: Tips for stoking curiosity. *Global Business and Organizational Excellence*, 44(3), 5–10. <https://doi.org/10.1002/joe.22278>
- Whetten, D. A. (1989). What constitutes a theoretical contribution? *Academy of Management Review*, 14(4), 490–495. <https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.1989.4308371>
- Wilcox, C. (2023). *ScienceAdviser*: Scientists are publishing too many papers—and that's bad for science. *Science*. <https://www.science.org/content/article/scienceadviser-scientists-are-publishing-too-many-papers-and-s-bad-science>
- World Economic Forum. (2023). How much progress is being made on the UN's Sustainable Development Goals? <https://www.weforum.org/agenda/2023/09/un-sustainable-development-goals-progress-report/>
- Yadav, M. S. (2010). The decline of conceptual articles and implications for knowledge development. *Journal of Marketing*, 74(1), 1–19. <https://doi.org/10.1509/jmk.74.1.1>
- Yorks, L. (2005). Nothing so practical as a good theory. *Human Resource Development Review*, 4(2), 111–113. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1534484305276176>
- Zeithaml, V. A., Jaworski, B. J., Kohli, A. K., Tuli, K. R., Ulaga, W., & Zaltman, G. (2020). A theories-in-use approach to building marketing theory. *Journal of Marketing*, 84(1), 32–51. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022242919888477>

Weng Marc Lim is a Distinguished Professor and the Dean of Sunway Business School at Sunway University, an ASU-Cintana Alliance Global Partner Affiliate Faculty at Arizona State University, and an Adjunct Professor at Sungkyunkwan University and Swinburne University of Technology, where he served as Dean, Head of School, Professor, and the University Council at the Sarawak campus. He has served as the Editor in Chief of *Global Business and Organizational Excellence*; Deputy Editor of *Journal of Global Marketing*; Associate Editor of *Journal of Business Research*, *Journal of Consumer Behaviour*, *Journal of Strategic Marketing*, and *The International Journal of Management Education*; and Regional Editor of *The Service Industries Journal*. He has authored more than 100 manuscripts in journals ranked 'A*' and 'A' such as *Australasian Marketing Journal*, *European Journal of Marketing*, *Industrial Marketing Management*, *International Journal of Advertising*, *Journal of Advertising*, *Journal of Advertising Research*, *Journal of Business Research*, *Journal of Business and Industrial Marketing*, *Journal of Consumer Behaviour*, *Journal of Consumer Marketing*, *International Journal of Consumer Studies*, *Journal of Brand Management*, *Journal of Product and Brand Management*, *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, *Journal of International Marketing*, *Journal of Marketing Management*, *Journal of Strategic Marketing*, *Marketing Theory*, *Marketing Intelligence & Planning*, and *Psychology & Marketing*, among others. He has also led high-level discussions at the AppliedHE, Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB), Association of MBAs (AMBA), Business Graduates Association (BGA), Nikkei Forum, Quacquarelli Symonds (QS), Times Higher Education (THE), United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) and Principles of Responsible Management Education (UNPRME), and World Economic Forum (WEF). Contact: @limwengmarc on Instagram and Twitter (X), LinkedIn, or his personal homepage at <https://www.wengmarc.com>.